

CHROMYRE CHRONICLES

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Front cover art by Yoyo Fang.

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Chess & Narrative

Plymouth, MI

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Plymouth Scholars Charter Academy

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*For the kingdom of Chromyre,
which lived because fourteen
students imagined it.*

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The Game

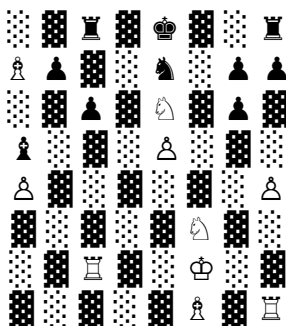
Sixty-seven moves

1. e4 Nf6 2. e5 Ng4 3. f4 Nh6 4. h3 Nc6 5. d4 Nf5
6. d5 Na5 7. g4 Nh6 8. g5 Ng8 9. b4 Nc4 10. Nc3 Nb6
11. a4 d6 12. Nf3 dxe5 13. fxe5 Nxd5 14. Nxd5 c6
15. Nf4 Bf5 16. Ra2 Qxd1+ 17. Kxd1 Rd8+ 18. Ke1
Bxc2 19. Rxc2 e6 20. h4 Bxb4+ 21. Kf2 Rc8 22. Be3
Ne7 23. Bxa7 Ba5 24. g6 fxg6 25. Nxe6 Rg8 26. Nfd4
Ra8 27. Nxc6 bxc6 28. Bc5 Ra6 29. Bxa6 Bc7 30. Kf3
Bxe5 31. Re2 Bb8 32. Rh3 Nd5 33. Rd2 Nc3 34. a5 Nb1
35. Rg2 Rf8+ 36. Ke2 Rf6 37. Nxg7+ Kf7 38. Rxc6
Kxc6 39. Ne8 Rf8 40. Nd6 Rd8 41. Nb7 Rd5 42. Bf8
Rd8 43. Ba3 Rd4 44. Bf8 Bf4 45. Nd8 c5 46. Ne6 c4
47. Bxc4 Rxc4 48. a6 Ra4 49. Nc5 Rxa6 50. Nxa6 Bd6
51. Rg3+ Kf6 52. Rg8 Bxf8 53. Rxf8+ Kg7 54. Rf1
Nc3+ 55. Kf2 Ne4+ 56. Kg1 Nc5 57. h5 Nxa6 58. Rf5
Kh6 59. Kf2 Nc5 60. Rxc5 Kg7 61. Rc7+ Kh8 62. h6
Kg8 63. Ke2 Kf8 64. Rxh7 Kg8 65. Rc7 Kf8 66. h7 Ke8
67. h8=Q#

1-0 · White wins

Chapter 1

The Last Normal Days



Moves 25-50 · shown at move 25

— Yu —

THUMP THUMP THUMP Yu, a half beast man, half human with yellow hair and horse ears, sprints with a large travel wagon behind him down the forest path. The sound rattles the forest's peaceful atmosphere, trekking dirt behind him. Today is hot and sunny but with a cool breeze, making the perfect day for profits.

"Money, money, money, money~ la-lala-la" Yu is singing to himself happily as he runs at 28 mph. The path before him is long but he endures it with the thoughts of profit. After a while, Yu takes a

break. Something catches his eye. There is a vibrant blue mushroom with purple lines running through the cap. He looks at it, a bit disgusted, as if mushrooms are the most filthy things to ever exist, but reluctantly picks them to sell. He isn't sure what this mushroom is, but he takes a break to rest in his wagon. On an average day without sales, Yu will start restocking on his most sold items such as arrows and potions. His cauldron is always filled with a potion that's brewing even while he travels.

After the break, Yu gets back on the run to get to his destination. Chromyre, the kingdom of trade, the place where his dreams of gold and platinum may come true.

"Halt right there!" A loud voice thunders as Yu arrives at Chromyre. Yu screeches to a halt suddenly, the stop is a bit hard due to the speed he was running at. There is a city guard standing by the gates to the kingdom.

"Yes?" Yu asks, a bit frightened by the loud voice.

"We need to check your wagon."

"O-oh yeah right, haha..."

"Move." The guard demands as he and his peers check the cargo. Yu shuffles a bit nervously knowing that he has some dangerous and special items stored inside the wagon.

"Why do you have weapons?" The guard inquires.

"Oh, uhm, I have my merchant's guild badge somewhere..." Yu takes out a polished purple badge, signifying that he's a highly trusted member. "HAHA! *cough cough* I mean uh, here's my qualifiers."

"Okay. Open the gates." The guard turns back and orders the others.

At last, Yu is finally able to enter the kingdom. He rolls his wagon to the nearby inn and parks there.

"Hello, what would you like?" The innkeeper asks Yu.

"Can I get 1 large ice cold lemonade?" Yu asks. It may be a childish order, but magic strawberries aren't good for horses.

"Sure, that'll be 1 copper."

"Thanks." Yu nods his head and waits for his lemonade. While he waits, he takes a deep breath after the long day of just running to the kingdom and writes in his journal about his observations.

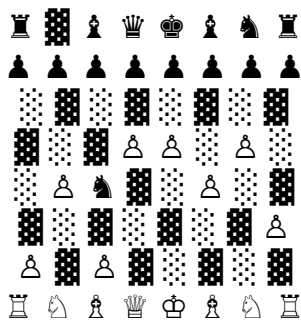
New knights are hostile and idiotic. People are irritating as usual but it seems like there's more aristocrats settling here. As Yu finishes writing down everything, his lemonade is set in front of him. He finishes up the lemonade and walks outside to look around. The trading market seems dense with villagers, stalls opened and several shops along the pathway with people trying to hustle for lower prices. This was gonna be a long day.

After a few hours, Yu finds a nice spot to settle his wagon. He opens the curtains and puts up his sign. *Shop of Wonders*. A decently well known traveling merchant's shop with a reputation for high pricing, high reward. Yu does look like a sketchy dealer, but he's been in this kingdom before. Now he's in the capital, Indmere.

"Thanks for buying! Come back soon!" Yu says after the last customer leaves. He goes to close his shop. When the long day finally ends, Yu goes to the local bathhouse with his sleeping clothes and

a towel. After cleaning up, he rolls out his tarp to sleep in the wagon.

. . .



Moves 10-50 · shown at move 10

— Xanthos —

I walked around the kingdom to get my usual things from the merchant named Yu.

"Hi Yu, what are you selling today?" I asked. Yu said he got a bunch of things, including swords, bows, and arrows, and physical enhancement potions. "I'll just get that durability potion. How much is it?" Yu said about 20 coins. 20! Are you trying to scam me? Whatever, I'll get it. I paid, and Yu gave me my potion. Since when does Yu make his goods overpriced? I walked through the busy

kingdom to an alley and saw Max, a dragonborn I mentored a while back, but now he is easily bribed. The kingdom has a lot of wealth, but who knows.

"Max, you can't hide," I said.

"Hello Xanthos, how has life been?" he replied.

"Fine," I said.

"Also fine, I just got a bunch of money from Major Potato, I am stacked!"

I sighed. "When did I ever teach you to do things for money?"

"To be honest, I don't really know, I just became obsessed with money, anyways I need to go, plus the sun is setting, we have to sleep soon. Until next time, Xanthos."

Max jumped over the few shops. I said goodbye and went to sleep.

The next day, I was in a corner talking with Max, Henry Emily, and Robert. Henry Emily is a very brave human knight, and Robert, a fallen angel, has been friends with Henry since childhood, so it's understandable that they talk to each other the most. As we were talking, the

general, Major Potato, came and greeted us. We all said "Hup!" Then we all told jokes and talked about what's going on with us. Henry said that Potato picked a name for his army, since it's the most diverse and unique in the kingdom, like Napoleon's Grand Armée.

We all said "Yeah!", but he said he has to ask the king for permission and agreed for us to have training next week and bid us farewell. When Potato left, I could see Queen Jerrica practicing archery in the field. Due to my excellent vision, I could tell she got 3 bullseyes in 3 out of the 4 targets. I could talk with her, but Potato was heading towards her direction, so I decided to leave them alone.

I said goodbye and walked around the kingdom for a while. Near the south wall I saw the other group — Rowan and Jocelyn at their cart, Stormy bothering Kizzlefitch as usual, Kerian juggling for coins, Zarathura standing off to the side by herself, and Monk sitting on a barrel watching everyone. I didn't have enough time to say hi, but they know me well enough.

At night, 10 minutes before the kingdom's curfew, Major Potato needed to talk with me

urgently.

"What is it, General?" I said.

Potato replied, "I heard reports of a plague."

"A Plague!" I said, shocked.

"Yeah, and it has very strong symptoms."

"Have you told the whole kingdom yet?"

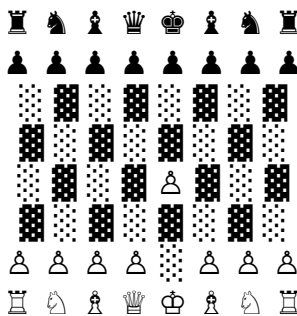
"No, I only told the King, Robert, Stormy, Kizzlefitch, and Jocelyn. I don't want to cause kingdom-wide panic, but the king will."

"So, what do we do?" I asked.

"We need to be on high alert, prepare all the defenses if the plague reaches the kingdom."

"It'll be done," I said firmly, and went to sleep in my tent.

. . .



Moves 1-60 · shown at move 1

— Rowan —

"Trrrrr Trrrrr"

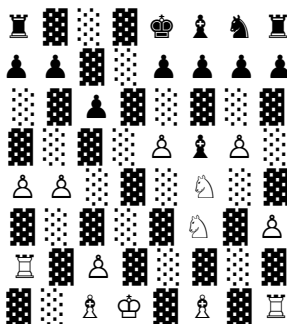
"Oh jiminy, these goshdang crickets, always ringin in my ear!"

I saw a butterfly fluttering through the garden, and I lost focus, causing me to trip on my book I left on the ground. I stumbled into the garden, spilling the watering pot and falling to my knees. I laid there dramatically lifeless, looking at the sky, filled with weariness and defeat from my long day. Finally, after I had my dramatic moment, I jumped up and began to dust off my overalls. I saw my neighbor dancing down the street. I stopped

dusting off my pants, confused. He danced all the way to his doorstep then suddenly stopped. Before I had time to judge, he threw up right in his monstera. My stomach dropped, and a squeak came out of my mouth. Did he really just ruin that beautiful monstera I sold him? I decided that this was none of my business and it was just more money for me, so I continued to water the plants. You never know what will happen here in Chromyre so you learn to just ignore things.

Chapter 2

First Signs



Moves 17-29 · shown at move 17

— Kerian —

It's like any other day for Kerian, as usual he has to entertain the king and queen. Just usual jester activities. He's realized ways to use his magic to entertain them. He has grass in his puffy jester pants so he won't sprout tomatoes when he's performing. He will shoot small sprouts into the air, barely using any mana.

By the time Kerian is allowed to go on break, he takes a walk in the forest, munching on the tomatoes he's grown on his head and in his garden. As he walks through the forest he sees his

childhood home. Reminding him from all the bad memories from back then. The times he's run away or tried to end it. He mutters something under his breath, only the trees around to hear.

Tears prick his eyes as he wanders to the back of the small cottage, where they had buried his brother. Kerian was only 6, his brother was 10 when he had gotten into a bad argument with their father. It was bad. Kerian had been sobbing in his room, barely understanding what was going on. He was so little, so small and fragile. He couldn't stand shouting since then.

He flinches when someone talks a bit loud, he avoids arguments as much as possible. When he hears the yelling. He thinks about what happened. He remembers finding his brother's body on the floor, barely alive. Kerian had run to town, trying to get help but nobody would listen. I mean who would listen to a little peasant boy whose family was worth nothing.

He finds a nearby flower and places it on the grave. He sits next to it, avoiding the area where the body would lay. Trying to show respect.

"I miss you, Sage. I really do. I'm so sorry for what happened back then. I know I can't help you now since it was in the past," the tears that once pricked his eyes now roll down his cheeks. "I can't help but feel responsible for it. I could've found a medic if I tried hard enough. I tried, Sage." Kerian says between tears, wishing he could be with his brother. In his warm arms, inhaling his gentle nature-y scent. He misses the comfort he can no longer get.

"Bye Sage, I'll come back tomorrow. You know I always do...if those we've lost are truly able to communicate with those who are alive. I've started to lose faith in that belief honestly. Maybe send me a sign, send some hope my way." He then mutters out a small please.

He gets up and returns to the kingdom. He heads to the castle, finding where the queen and king are. They're having an argument when he comes in. His breathing speeds.

"Oh crap...not now not now" he chants in his head, wishing for this to all be over. The king notices Kerian standing there.

"What are you doing, peasant? Come on. Entertain or be thrown in the dungeon."

"S-sorry your highness." He obliges and gets on with doing the usual acts. He thinks they may be boring, but as he jokes around, he thinks of new things to do. He juggles his three balls. As he juggles, he loses his grip and the pink ball rolls away. He immediately tosses the other one and plays it off as part of the act. He goes and grabs each one, and as he does so he drops one and trips over it purposely, falling in the funniest way possible.

He repeats the dropping and tripping a few times. He notices the king and queen looking extremely bored. He picks up the balls, putting them back under his hat. He begins the next act.

He starts mocking the king and queen, making jokes about their roles in the kingdom. He says one wrong thing.

"You're useless in the kingdom, people do everything for you while you sit on your throne acting so high and mighty." Kerian said it without thinking. He never meant to go that extreme. It wasn't funny. There was nothing but rage in the

king's eyes.

"Guards. GUARDS. Take him to the dungeon. Put him in the most cramped and cold cell.

NOW!" The king shouts at the guards. They take him and put him into the torture room. They tie him down and leave him there. One guard stays and gives him a talk about what happened.

Luckily they're nice about it.

"So, kid, remember. You can insult him, but not about occupation or who he loves, like him loving the queen and what not. You'll just be sent here again," the guard's eyes soften, seeing the way that Kerian's breathing has quickened and his eyes are looking everywhere but at the guard. "Hey kid, I won't hurt you. Alright? You just need to understand what you can and can't say."

The guard gently grabs Kerian's shoulder and takes him to a cell. It's small and cramped, but it's better than what the king wanted for him.

"I'll talk to the king about how long you'll be here, I'll bring supper down for you. It'll be that slop they feed everyone. I may sneak you some of my food though since I'll be on guard duty around supper time." The guard passes Kerian a book

titled 'Jokes for Jesters, a king friendly guide'

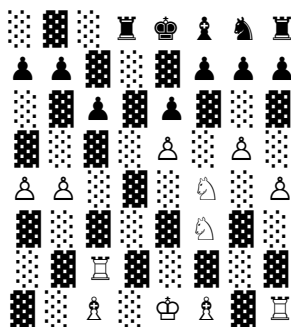
and leaves.

When supper time comes around, the guard returns with food for him. The guard puts a bit of his own meal onto the empty part of the dish.

Kerian's day is awfully boring, not much to do other than read the book the guard gave him for the 53rd time around. He eats supper, not wasting a drop. Not knowing when the next meal would come since they usually forget about him when he's in the dungeon. Or anyone in the dungeon. He also gets forgotten on normal days so he always heads to his house and makes some form of food.

He mostly will make something using his crops he grows in his garden. He stocks up on seeds from Yu whenever they are available or he runs into Yu.

...



Moves 20-53 · shown at move 20

— Jocelyn —

"Seriously! Did Kizzlefitch mess the garden up again?"

I swear she is so annoying, she needs to mess with someone else. Now I have to clean this mess up. I just finished working in the garden with Rowan. She is so annoying, and I despise living with her, but I unfortunately have to. But anyway, back to cleaning this disarray of a garden.

A few hours later Finally, the garden is back to being perfect. Then I see Rowan from the corner of my eye through the window, sitting in the house and reading in the corner like she always is. Never

doing work in the garden, but always reading. I walk through the front door and scold, "What are you doing? I told you to go to the shops and sell the tools! Get up and go!"

She obviously doesn't budge, and continues reading. I scoff and leave her be, she is one stubborn girl I have to live with. I continue my night as always, picking fresh food from my garden and making dinner for both of us, before taking a walk and heading to bed.

I wake up bright and early in the morning, the crisp, cool air hitting my face from the window. I step out of bed and get ready for the day, throwing on my light green dress, the one I always wear. After that, I walk into the kitchen and notice Rowan isn't awake yet, so I trudge my way up into her room.

I nudge the door open and see her fast asleep, her room looking like a tornado has happened. I sigh and start to wake her up, "Rowan, get up. I need you to sell at the shops today, unlike yesterday."

After she takes off for the shops, I decide to take a seat and give the garden a rest for today.

Today is Wednesday, the mailman usually comes to drop my packages. Right on cue, there is a knock on my door. I go to retrieve the mail and something catches my eye, a slip of paper that says, "WARNING! A NEW PLAGUE HAS BEEN DISCOVERED! IT IS CALLED THE EPHEMERAL CHOREOMANIA!"

I take a good look at it before setting it down in the trash. No way that is real, it can't be. It's probably just some kids making drama. Rowan ends up coming back home weirdly early, I ask her, "why are you back so soon?"

"You won't believe what happened—" I cut her off sharply.

I immediately told her, "just tell me what you sold."

"I didn't sell anything, just let me explain," she replies quietly.

She then goes to explain what happened to her and it all clicks. The plague is real. I pull the paper out of the garbage and show it to her. It is the answer to her questions.

— Kizzlefitch —

She was reckless. She pranked the knights. She messed up Jocelyn's garden for no reason and bothered Rowan whenever she felt like it. Stormy

hated her and he was her only friend. She was the loudest person in any room she entered and she did not care.

She was also the first authority figure to witness the plague firsthand.

A trader named Aldric was arguing beside the central fountain when his cheek twitched.

"I told you the price was final!" he shouted, slamming a mug down on the stone edge of the fountain. "You want cheaper grain, go argue with the farmers!"

Then his fingers jerked hard enough that he dropped his drink. The mug shattered on the cobblestones. He laughed it off. "Bad nerves," he said with a grin. "Too much coffee this morning."

By the next day his arm was jerking every few minutes. On the third day he collapsed near the same fountain, vomiting, his limbs twisting beneath him. Then the movements changed. They became smoother. Almost rhythmic. Aldric was dancing. Aldric was also screaming.

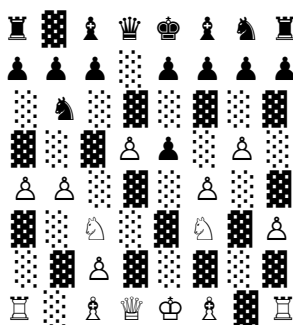
"MAKE IT STOP!" he shouted between gasps.

Kizzlefitch pushed through the crowd and knelt beside him. She tried her dark healing magic — the sort that forces the body back into working order. His breathing steadied.

The dance continued. Aldric spun once, stumbled, and his heart stopped.

Within a week the city had changed. Markets closed early. Streets emptied at night. People watched each other, waiting for the first twitch.

. . .



Moves 1-60 · shown at move 13

— Rowan —

"I'll be right back, I am just going to go get supplies from Indmere, it should only take me until the sun goes down."

"Okay Jocelyn, I will see you when you get back," I said with mischief in my eyes.

I waited for Jocelyn to be out of sight. I quickly grabbed my book, ran inside, and locked myself in the closet. Jocelyn always thought reading was a waste of time when she could be selling more tools or working in the garden. I was almost done with my book and this was the perfect time to finish it. I began reading.

"So comes snow after fire, and even dragons have their endings..."

I heard a loud bang on the front door. Lost in my book, I completely lost track of time. The sun was still up so it couldn't be Jocelyn. Scared, I jumped up and walked carefully to the door not making a sound. Maybe it's KizzleFitch, that stupid goblin is always messing with me. I looked through the window with my head low and saw it was Jocelyn. I let her in with no plan as of what to say.

"Why aren't you in the garden? You have work to do!" Jocelyn vocalized with anger.

"Umm...ahhh...well...I...ahh," I stuttered with no other response.

"Just stop. You are so difficult I can't leave you to do anything! Just go back out there and keep working!" She snapped.

I worked out there every day for hours. When Jocelyn wasn't yelling at me to work, I really enjoyed it. It was starting to get dark so I finished up and went to go rest.

The next day "Rowan, I need you to sell at the shops today," Jocelyn states loudly as she walks up the stairs.

"Ugh...." I groaned as I rolled on to the floor next to my bed with a loud thump.

Jocelyn reached the top of the stairs and looked into my room, "Oh my goodness, why are you still sleeping?"

I groaned, "Obviously I'm not sleeping anymore."

I got up with weary eyes and a sluggish body. It was sunny today, but it was oddly windy out from what I could see out my window. I threw on fresh clothes and hurried downstairs to make breakfast. Practically unconscious, I made my way to the door with my shop cart and my merchant guild badge. It was uncomfortably colder than usual, so

I tried to make my walk quick.

I walked into the capital, Indmere, when I noticed a girl with what seemed like an uncontrollable cough. I thought nothing of it until her hands started shaking. All my attention was on her until I tripped and fell into a puddle.

"Ahh...ugh..." I groaned as I got up, "*huff* My clothes!"

I got up out of the puddle sopping wet with nothing on my mind except frustration.

"Hey, are you okay?" an unknown voice asked.

"I mean yeah... I guess," I said with my back turned away from this mysterious vocal source.

Cough Cough Cough My head whipped around to see who this was coughing on me. I had never seen this man around here before. I backed up, aggressively stunned that this person just coughed on me.

"What the heck!" I exclaimed with anger.

Cough Cough Cough "What is your problem?"

Cough Cough Cough "Ugh, would you stop? Get away from me!"

I ran off with my cart and supplies. I was so confused and shocked at what was happening around me. I reached where I was going to set up shop and organized my things. I put a drop of Jocelyn's Speedy Sprout Serum (Potion that makes any object larger) on my cart to enlarge it for taller, less awesome, customers. I see another person dancing down the street while tears filled their eyes. My brain couldn't take the confusion anymore so I packed up shop immediately and practically ran back to the cottage.

"Why are you back so soon?" Jocelyn asked.

"You will never believe what has been happening!" I exclaimed out of breath.

"Just tell me how much you made," Jocelyn said with frustration.

"...I didn't sell anything..." I said with fear.

Jocelyn disappointedly shouted, "WHAT?"

"Just let me explain!" I shouted with impatience. "People were dancing... and...and puking...and coughing...and...*huff huff*..."

"Slow down, I have news from the paper possibly related to what you saw," she said with

concern. "Read here."

WARNING: THE EPHEMERAL
CHOREOMANIA PLAGUE This rampant and
highly-contagious plague is spreading through the
kingdom. The Ephemeral Choreomania is a plague
that attacks the nervous system, making the
person unable to control their own bodies. There
are 4 stages to this virus.

Each stage lasts 1-2 days.

Stage 1: Abnormal twitching in the face.
Extreme coughing. Unstable and shaking hands.

Regular appetite. The "spores" infect 1/15
people usually, they are weak and haven't had
time to "grow."

Stage 2: The person is unable to feel one of
their arms, making it hard to control how it
moves.

Sometimes it moves uncontrollably as if it
belonged to someone else. They get less hungry,
the appetite is lost with a bit of stomach pain.
They can still eat. The "spores" infect 1/10 people.

Stage 3: Vomiting begins. Eating is essential
but it is difficult to keep it down. Sometimes their

hands start pinching themselves. Their mind changes to be more violent and they become more aggressive towards others. Their struggling looks like a dance. The "spores" they emit are decently strong, it would infect 1/4 people.

Stage 4: The person begins to be paralyzed and starts having a harder time to move how they want. Their movements are controlled by a part of their brain. They try to go near others to infect them. The "spores" that they emit are the strongest and have the best chance to infect others at this time. It will infect 3/8 people.

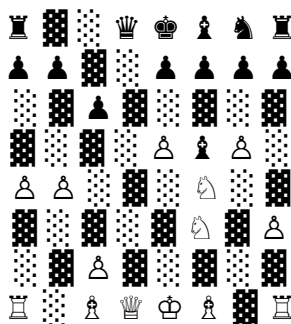
STAY INSIDE AND PROTECTED. THERE IS NO KNOWN CURE. STAY SAFE.

"WHAT?" I shouted with immense concern and fear.

Jocelyn and I both look out the window where screams fill the streets. More people are puking and frolicking along the roads. We ran down the stairs and locked the door.

Thump Thump Thump Thump Thump Click For the rest of the day Jocelyn let me do inventory and reading.

...



Moves 16-38 · shown at move 16

— Max —

Carnage, sleep, suffering everywhere you look; someone is suffering. But it wasn't always like this. 40 days earlier. Everything was as normal as it should be. Max had recently disposed of another victim and collected his paycheck. So now he won't starve this week. It is a prosperous time in the Chromyre kingdom. He's been able to make a good living here. Yet little did he know that things would go horribly wrong.

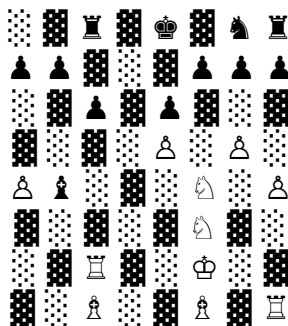
One day before the virus There are starting to be rumors that a new plague has come. People call it The Ephemeral Choreomania. It's said that it makes people lose control of their bodies. Now

everyone is getting ready for a full on virus. Max thought this was going to be trouble and man it was. Everyone was rushing to the market to get supplies. There were all kinds of shady deals going on, where people claimed they had the cure. But yet for some reason everyone was suddenly collapsing after drinking it.

First Day of the virus.

There are already people starting to succumb to the virus. With all the carnage going on outside it is hard to believe this is the real world. Max decided to take a stroll and see what was happening before everything went terribly wrong. But before he could even step outside he already saw two people violently coughing and they had these spores in small bunches on their body. So with common sense Max turned right around and went into hiding.

...



Moves 22-44 · shown at move 22

— Robert Topala —

2 months before the plague This was the day Robert was falsely accused of sin; he was brutally beaten by the other angels, leaving him with a bright gold scar across his face and many bruises. He was then sent to earth, his divine essence, making him mortal. A portal opens in the sky as Robert is shot out of heaven: "AGHAAHHHHHHH HHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHH H."

With a crash, he lands in a field, on top of his childhood friend, coincidentally (Henry Emily).

Henry painfully stands, "Ow, dude, watch it, man, dude!"

Robert stares for about 3 seconds, "Henry?"

Henry stares for another 3 seconds. "Robert? Why are you so...dark now?"

"Long story," Robert replies.

"And what happened to your wings?!" Henry adds, "They look blended."

"To put it short, I got a dude really mad so he accused me of talking bad about the Holy Council, now I'm a fallen angel!" Robert remarks.

Henry then cheerfully exclaims, "Well, C'mon lemme show you the town!"

Day 1 of the plague, the Ephemeral Choreomania Robert looks outside, points at a guy, and looks at Henry. "What's his issue?" The guy he's pointing at is eating an enormous amount of food while twitching weirdly.

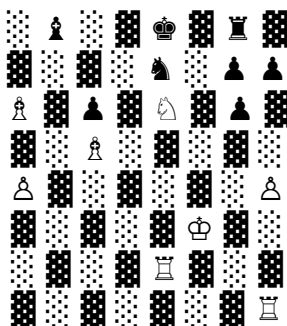
"Drug abusers," Henry says. More and more people get similar symptoms, not many, but it's definitely spreading. Robert, while mending his gear, speaks to Henry, "Yeah, there is no way this is drugs or a virus." He then snatches Henry's

lamp (the only thing lighting his room) for fun.

Henry then introduces Robert to Major Potato, Max, and Xanthos. *Scrrr-shhhhhhhh*. Robert picks up his blade and examines the edge. "Good as new!"

Chapter 3

The Kingdom Splits



Moves 32-65 · shown at move 32

— Monk —

The healer needed a physician. She got a monkey.

She said it to the guard. I was standing right there.

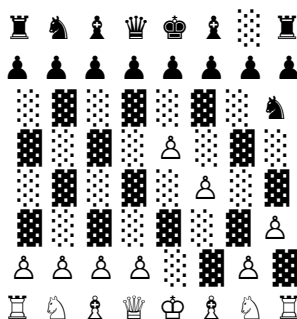
I picked up the mop. There was marinara on the floor.

There was a woman sitting outside on the steps sharpening a sword. She had been there when I arrived and she was still there when I finished. She did not speak to me. She did not speak to anyone. I asked one of the other orderlies who she

was.

"She's taken the Quietening," he said, like that explained it.

I wrote it down. Page one.



Moves 4-14 · shown at move 4

— Stormy —

SHWUCK.

My dagger sliced into the head of the dummy. I pressed the button on my crossbow, bringing the pumpkin head back to me. I loved to train for a war, even if there wasn't a war happening.

"My name is Stormy. I am a dragonborn mercenary working for the government. I am experienced, so anyone who tries to fight me—"

"Extra! Extra! A plague forces citizens into hiding! Also, who are you talking to?" yells a paperboy. I look at him.

"Shut up. I am monologuing for my autobiography, if you must know. Now scram! I have work to do..."

A couple of days later, a new news report comes in.

"The plague's cure is being produced by scientists! Symptoms include uncontrollable dancing, vomiting, etc. Stay away from anyone who you think is infected! Report casualties to the police!"

the headline reads. I scowl.

"Why would anyone try to come up with a cure? This thing would have governments begging for our mercy! All we need is to infect one citizen, and BAM! A whole city is ours to command!"

"Uh, who're you talking to? Also, the paper costs 1 copper now, so..." The paperboy holds out a pouch. I drop a silver as a tip, because this guy is the only person to approach me for weeks, other than Kizzlefitch, whom I hate, but is my only friend.

"Thanks a lot, sir! Have a wonderful day!" He bounds along the path. Little does he know, I want something more than happiness: Power.

I frown. The leaders didn't want us to harness the plague. They said that it would "turn our citizens against us." Whatever that means.

I trudge home in despair, when I run into a horrific sight. A lady starts vomiting everywhere.

"BLEHHH!" I watch in horror as the woman spews everywhere!

"Someone get the medics! She's sleeping!"

A few minutes later, the medics arrive. She is carried to a hospital, but we all know that she is not surviving that. But I get an idea...

"Hello, sir! How can we help you toda-"

I hold up my mercenary badge. "I need to see the patient who was just taken in here.

Government orders."

She looks at me, startled. "I'm sorry, sir, but I'm afraid she didn't make it," she tells me. Then she starts to whisper. "We have her body in the back, but wear gloves so that you don't get infected.

Good luck!"

On my way through I passed that monkey. Monk. He was mopping the floor, which was pretty funny actually. A monkey with a mop. He looked at the syringe in my hand.

"You should not take that out of here," he said. "That marinara is infected. If the vial breaks near anyone the spores will—"

"Mind your business, Monk." I pushed past him. What does a monkey know about bioweapons?

This sample was going to change everything.

I grab the gloves and put them on. I opened the door, and almost threw up. The whole room was filled with juice boxes of victims. I grab my syringe, and poke one of the juice boxes in the straw. The marinara is brown and thick, and has some white splotches in it. I shudder. This is what could've been going through my straws if I hadn't stepped away from the woman.

I grab it, and rush out. On my way home, I run into Xanthos. He greets me cheerfully, and we chat.

"Did you hear about the plague? I heard that it makes people dance uncontrollably," he tells me.

I nod.

"I saw someone get taken by it. The scene was gruesome! I never want to experience something like it ever again!"

But as soon as I say that, I lurch. The ground starts spinning.

"Hey, are you ok? Should I get a medic?"

I fall to the ground, and vomit everywhere. How could this have happened? I didn't come in contact with anyone who had the plague! I feel terrible. Xanthos looks at me and yells, "MEDIC!!

STORMY IS SLEEPING!"

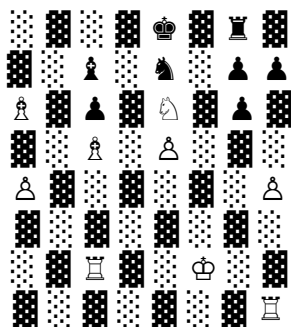
I look up at him. "Take... this... it is a sample... give it to someone to study... as... a final...

request..." I hand him the string, and he puts it into his pocket.

I see my favorite memories. First time holding a sword. Getting approved to be a mercenary.

Spending time with my few friends. It all floats away, and everything goes black...

. . .



Moves 10-50 · shown at move 30

— Xanthos —

After I woke up, I saw Stormy run up to me, and I greeted him cheerfully. I said, "Did you hear about the plague?" "I heard it makes people dance uncontrollably," I said. Stormy said, "He saw someone get taken by it. The scene was gruesome! I never want to experience something like that ever again."

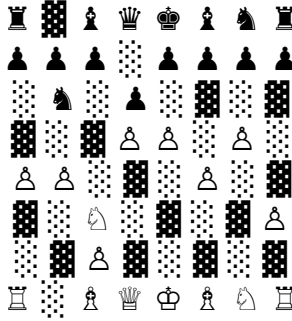
After he said that, he lurched. I said, "Are you okay? Should I get a medic?" Then, he vomited like crazy. I screamed, "MEDIC!! STORMY IS SLEEPING!" He gave me a sample, likely for the cure.

He told me all the good times he had, and slept. I yelled for something very wrong for his sleep. I make soup every time, and he always eats it, so who is gonna eat all my soup? I don't want it to go to waste. Also, you stole my ivory-made centaur sculpture! I had to pay triple the price from Yu and you stole it!.

I looked at the syringe he had pressed into my hand. It was full of something brown and thick. I did not know what it was or what he expected me to do with it. I put it in my pocket. It seemed important to him, so I kept it.

The whole kingdom was in panic. My other friends, including Major Potato, believed there was a cure by a sample Stormy gave before he slept, and the others, those like Rowan and Kizzlefitch, believed a cure was impossible and wanted to sacrifice anybody who was affected.

...



Moves 12-27 · shown at move 12

— Henry Emily —

My first battle as a knight - Day -1507 My muscles start to tense as enemy ballistas destroy the frontlines on the war-torn battlefield. I wear the last piece of my armor to get ready for battle: my helmet. I grab my longsword from the table, which is underneath the war tent. It is chaotic out on the battlefield. People are getting poked, and their noodles are oozing out of their lunchboxes. Others are screaming with the intensity of a hand cannon getting shot. I focus on myself. I need to help them.

I advance towards the battlefield, narrowly avoiding a ballista bolt that grazes my pauldron,

resulting in its destruction. The urgency of the situation moves me forward, as I remain aware of the looming danger around me. My black hair slightly covers my already bad view since I'm wearing a knight's helmet.

I find a mage warrior using a plancon to decimate my fellow soldiers. I propel myself towards him, swinging my longsword at his shoulder. "Shouldn't have tried that," he says, as he pokes my shoulder with the plancon. "You Presian scum.." I mutter, poking his collarbone. He retaliates with an energy blast at my chest. My breastplate and chainmail absorb most of the force, but I still wince in pain. I find an opening, and so I take it. I grab the blade of my longsword, smashing the pommel against his head.

He yelps in pain, his s'more broken. I force another attack on his s'more, damaging it more. I see his marshmallow slowly move out from the gap in his s'more. He's now a corpse on the war-torn floor.

I took a few infantry on the Presian side. I get my morale high, but not until I see the giant behemoth. The ultimatum of the battle. It's a dragon, a war dragon with the Presian emblem

burned into its neck, and it is gonna be the one to take me. Or so I thought.

It roars, its screech nearly ear-bleeding. I get into a normal battle stance. My brown eyes widen from under the helmet. Will I sleep here? In my first battle? The thought fills my mind, second by second. Its mouth opens, glowing a bright orange. I have to fight, no matter what. I have to soften it up for a ballista barrage by my allies— Before I can finish my thought, it shoots a beam of pure flames at me from its mouth. I disarm myself, making the dragon feel the weight of a passive magical ability: retaliation armament. It loses most of its skill and power, its massive frame tumbling down on the ground as it struggles to keep itself up. I grab my longsword, preparing to poke into its throat. But there's one problem.

Retaliation armament works if I'm disarmed.

The dragon picks itself up, swiping its head towards me. I get hit, and the force of the head swipe sends me flying multiple meters to the right. I get up, using my longsword to help me get up. My muscles shake. Overexertion already.

I nearly fall, but I catch myself with my hand. My vision blurs, and I feel my thoughts clawing at my head. I need to get out of this helmet! This is torture! I fight through the urge to get rid of my helmet, which would take me. The dragon shoots another beam of flames, but I activate my fog cloud ability. Due to the dragon not being able to see me, it missed by a few feet.

I use the opportunity to run at the dragon, poking its left front leg with my longsword. It shrieks in pain, kicking me with the same leg. I use the longsword to, instead of falling, skid across the ground. The battle of Chromyre and Presia rumbles around me, but I stay focused. Take this dragon, me! The dragon tries to bite me, but I leap over its head and onto the back of its neck. I poke the dragon's neck 5 times. It falls to the ground, but it's not sleeping. Its tail whips me off its neck, sending me flying to the left multiple meters away. I miraculously land on my feet, using my longsword to skid along the ground.

I realize my purpose in this battle now. I will be the one to take this dragon. I am ready to go on the defensive. The dragon flies at me, but I evade to the side, leaping and getting on its head. I poke

the dragon's meatball, jumping down and holding onto one of its corn kernels. It tries to shake me off, but I don't fall. It prepares a flame breath. I feel the heat from the distance I am away from the dragon's throat, but I don't let go. I reach out to grab the longsword by its hilt, ripping it out of its meatball and poking its noodle.

It shrieks, its flame breath cancelled. I rip the longsword out of the tongue, climbing on its head again. It tries to fly and shake me off from there, but I slide from its neck down to the back of the dragon, slicing its right wing so badly that the wing nearly dangles. It shrieks, falling down from the sky 6 meters down. I brace myself, feeling the THUD of the fall, but I don't fall. I run to its head, using the back of its neck as a bridge. I arrive on the top of its head, using the chance to PLUNGE my longsword down its graham cracker and into the marshmallow of the wild beast.

I fell off its head and onto my side. My vision blurs, but I can't give up, not yet. I get up, using my longsword as a way to help myself up. I see the aftermath of the battle. It's a Chromyre victory.

The Presians have fled into their castle, which is to be sieged once Chromyre's siege machines

arrive.

I go back to the field of Chromyre war tents to recuperate. I use my longsword as a cane due to my injuries. Adrenaline is the reason I was able to beat the dragon while wearing heavy armor.

The arrival of the Siege Machines - Day -1496 I wake up to the sound of trebuchets rolling across the dirt roads of the village-like war tent area.

I get up, carefully assembling my battle-damaged knight armor. I walk out of the war tent, the sight of crewmen and trebuchets surprising me. They arrived faster than expected.

"They say Presia has a golem and dragons, but we say we have a knight that can beat 'em all!"

An infantry soldier says to his fellow soldier, unaware of the knight's presence. I witnessed the crewmen ready the trebuchets and put the boulders in their designated positions.

The crewmen fire the boulders with the trebuchets at the Presian castle walls. The walls get decimated pretty quickly, the archers on the walls not having enough time to fire their heavy draw-weight bows due to the walls collapsing beneath them. My armor plating rattles from the

force of the boulders smashing against the walls, my chest feeling a wave of unusualness from the noise.

It seems like we will just storm the castle easily and take it over, but it's not that simple. "Guys, fellow soldiers, doesn't something feel weird?" I ask. "No, not at all!" An infantry soldier says with enthusiasm. "Guess it is just me, the—" The castle erupts in a huge burst of blue napalm. A giant, 19-meter-tall stone golem with neon blue markings is silhouetted in the blue napalm eruption. It walks towards where the army and I are. "What are you doing, fire the trebuc—" I get cut off by a huge beam of blue napalm coming from the golem's arm. The trebuchets and their crewmen were taken out. The biggest source of firepower is gone.

"There goes the time for me to be arrogant, I suppose," I say with great fear and courage. It shoots out a huge beam of blue napalm at me, but I cover my exposed right pauldron with my longsword. The napalm beam does nothing to pure, steel-triton plating. I slowly advance towards the golem. It continues to shoot me with blue napalm, but it takes a way longer time to

melt steel-triton than normal steel with that napalm-type.

I run at the golem, but it swipes me away and breaks my helmet and part of my breastplate. I got up just to see a blue napalm blast sent my way. I conjure a common offensive magic orb in my hand, using it to shoot an offensive magic beam at the blast. The beam breaks through the blast with ease, hitting the golem square in the chest. I shoot a barrage of offensive magic beams, the number of beams destroying the surroundings in front of me and behind the golem.

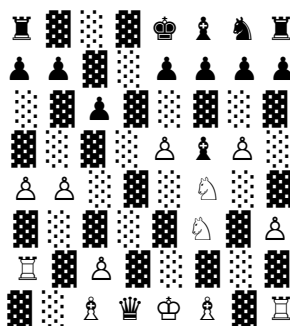
The golem gets slightly injured, and I run at it. It tries to attack me with physical attacks, but I use offensive magic blasts to send its arms away from my body. I infuse my gauntlet with explosive magic, jumping up and punching the golem with the explosive gauntlet.

BOOOM!

I haven't written anything yet, not in a while. But, I have to talk about what I have been experiencing... I've felt an inhuman twitching on my face. My coughs are starting to be so bad that I taste marinara in my throat. My hands are

shaking abnormally. It's hard to write. I'll do another check-in if this escalates.

The Queen Exchange



Moves 16-17 · shown at move 17

— Kizzlefitch —

Scholars, monks, and healers gathered in the temple district to study the victims. Kizzlefitch visited them every day.

Stormy was sleeping by then. She heard about it from a guard who heard it from someone in the square. Stormy had been obnoxious and reckless and the only person in the kingdom who talked to Kizzlefitch like she was a person instead of a title. She did not talk about his sleep. She went back to work.

The answer came from a young monk with dust on his robes and exhaustion in his eyes.

"Spores," he said.

Tiny fungal spores in the air. They clung to clothes, settled in hair, slipped into lungs. Once inside the body they attacked the nervous system. When the infected danced, they scattered more spores. Every victim was spreading the plague with every step.

Kizzlefitch shut the gates of Indmere. Merchants screamed about lost profits. Travelers pounded on the doors. She refused to reopen them.

The monks traced the earliest infections to dockworkers unloading grain shipments. The sacks had bypassed inspection. They had been rushed into city storage under royal authorization.

Only one person had the authority to approve that.

Kizzlefitch started watching the King. He left the palace at strange hours. He met with couriers no one recognized. Trade records showed more shipments arriving under his seal. Then she found the treasury reports. The kingdom's finances were

declining. Beside several population charts the King had written a single note in his own hand.

Necessary reductions. The plague was never an accident. He believed fewer people would mean fewer expenses. His plan was to introduce infected grain slowly so the sleeps would look natural. The spores spread faster than he predicted.

Kizzlefitch confronted him in the throne hall. She laid the evidence on the floor. Trade records.

Treasury notes. Shipment seals.

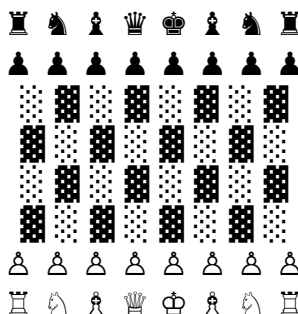
"Explain," she said.

He denied everything. He ordered the guards to arrest her. No one moved. Too many guards had watched neighbors collapse in the streets. Too many servants had buried family members.

She never finished what she started. A citizen — a sympathizer with the cure-seeking faction — assassinated her the next day. Whether the King arranged it or whether someone simply decided that a goblin who knew too much was a problem, no one could say for certain. The evidence she had gathered sat on the throne room floor. Nobody picked it up.

She slept believing she had failed.

...



Move 1

— Jerrica —

My name is Jerrica. Queen Jerrica. You've probably heard of me, seeing as I am the first minion archer in the history of this kingdom. I had humble origins, growing up in England, trying to find work to stay out of trouble. I was pretty ordinary, nothing out of the blue. Then I had an experience that changed my life forever. I was working in the shoe store I used to work at when an armed crook barged in, pointing his knife at me. That event shook me, and I vowed never to let anyone scare me like that again. So I decided to do something about it. I taught myself how to use a bow and arrow, as well as a range of advanced

combat skills, and before long, the king of the kingdom noticed my exceptional skills and appointed me the leader of the archers in his kingdom. Life is perfect now...or at least, it was. For the past few weeks, a deadly plague has been spreading through the kingdom. Hospitals are filled, and it's extremely contagious. It makes stomach acids rise so violently that victims of the virus throw up until they have nothing else to spew out, or it goes to their nervous system, and they lose total control of their movements and dance until they, well, sleep. And the terrifying part? I woke up today, and my hand started shaking (a symptom of the plague)...

Panicking, I immediately went to the kingdom's doctor, desperately trying to get a cure, despite being told there was none repeatedly. My hand was still shaking, but with more force now.

"Please, help me. My hand is shaking, and I think I might have the plague. I need a cure...I can't sleep like this, I'm too important," I desperately plead. "I'm sorry, honeybunchkins, there's nothing I can do. Here, have some ice..." Well, she's useless, I thought. I guess I'll just have to find a cure myself. So I set off on my journey to

find a cure for my worsening condition. As I wandered the streets of the kingdom, the streets were eerily quiet. Everyone was either locking themselves in their homes or in the hospital, fighting for their lives. My face twitched, and my stomach dropped as I realized the symptoms were getting worse. I started making my way over to Rowan and Jocelyn's garden, figuring that if there was one place to go, it would be there, because of the variety of plants and herbs they grew. After a few hours of walking, I reached their garden. I knocked a few times, waiting for an answer, but no one answered. I hesitated, not wanting to trespass, but the pure desperation of the situation got the better of me, and I entered. Then it struck me: I had absolutely no clue what plants were good for what, and realized the cure could be literally anything. I pulled out my book of plants from when I took a biology class in England, but even that was pretty useless. So I decided that things couldn't really get worse, and I started looking for plants that looked the least poisonous. After searching through numerous suspiciously colored plants for a while, I finally found one that looked fairly normal. It was a shortish plant with perfect green leaves that sprouted from its thin

stem, with purple veins popping noticeably. Well, what do I have to lose? I thought, and quickly rinsed it off and ate it.

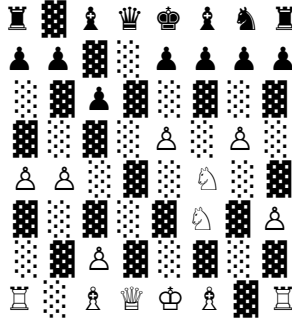
The flavor was nothing too unique, and I didn't have any pain or discomfort, which was reassuring. Suddenly, I started coughing. It was full on wheezing, couldn't breathe type of cough, choking on air. Tears streamed down my face as I held onto the wall to steady myself. Well, that was obviously not a cure. If anything, it made my situation worse. After a while, the coughing subsided, but never really went away fully. Panic flooded through me as I miserably scanned the garden for anything that might help. It was getting worse, and I was still trying to find a cure, or at least something that would make the pain and discomfort subside. Suddenly, my gaze landed on a sign enveloped in vines saying, "Medical stuff."

I breathed a sigh of relief, thinking I was saved. Surely there's something in here that might help, I thought hopefully. I devoured the first thing I saw, not thinking twice in my raw desperation. The label read something about "pain relief" and "use with caution." I didn't care. This time, it had a

peppermint-like taste, much stronger than the first plant, but I ignored the taste. It said it would relieve pain, and I was relying on the hope of that. And it did, temporarily, at least. The relief was short-lived. I stopped coughing, and my twitching got better. I've done it! I found the cure! I thought happily. I gathered my stuff to leave, when suddenly, I vomited violently. The "cure"

didn't work. I stood there in despair, and it happened. I started dancing. Well, I guess this is the end... I thought in despair. And then I slept.

...



Moves 15-19 · shown at move 15

— Zarathura —

I am a socially awkward elf that loves singing and reciting and writing poems, otherwise known as a bard. I know I am an elf. I should know how to be happy and social. I'm not. My skin tone is lime-green, dark brown eyes not too dark but still dark brown. I am five-seven and a little scrawny. I have short hair that is dark brown and wear an old wizard's hat.

"I walk in the kingdom on my daily walk."

While walking by I see a merchant. I go and buy something from there. "All of the person's stuff was really expensive to get so I only buy a

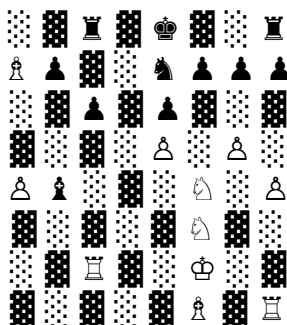
sword and a crossbow."

Plague Out Break "Doing my daily walk again and singing for the kingdom. Next thing I know everyone was moving their body everywhere doing things they couldn't control. I was scared, I didn't know what they were doing."

I visited a doctor and he told me there was a plague outbreak and that I should run for my lifeeeeeeee. Even though I was scared I had to stop being a baby and I tried my hardest to.

The Day I Slept There was a little kid that had the plague. He was trying to talk to me but I remembered what the doctor said, do not get near anybody with the plague. Instead of running I saved everybody the trouble by taking him with the new sword I bought. I went on walking but next thing I know a scythe was poked into my tomato by Max. Before I finally slept I heard Max saying "Sorry I got paid to do it," rage filled my heart and next thing you know I slept.

...



Moves 16-38 · shown at move 23

— Max —

Day 16 of the virus.

Max's windows are boarded up after the virus started getting worse and the infected tried to infect others. Another day of staying inside away from all the carnage but that's soon gonna change.

"Dang Nabbits!" Max said, staring at the empty food pantry.

Max heads over to his armory to gear up. As he is sifting through his stuff he wonders if he could make a cure for the infected. But that was not his main priority. Then he found a previous

assignment to complete. Since he was low on food he decided to complete it for money. He then proceeds to grab his best and favorite scythes. Then Max bursts through the door knocking an infected down to the ground. Leaping onto a neighboring balcony Max uses the rooftops to his advantage staying clear of all the infected down below. But his target's house is far away so as it turns dark Max takes a break on the rooftop. For a couple days Max started looting abandoned buildings for anything good.

Day 19 of the virus Quickly tracking down his target Zarathura. On his way to Zarathura's house Max sees marinara covered streets below. On top of the marinara there are many infected. But they were unlike he's ever seen. They are almost fully covered in spores. But Max needs to focus on the job at hand.

He then finds his house down and proceeds to jump through his window catching him off guard.

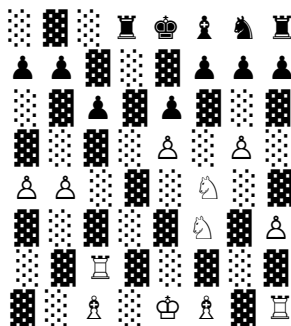
"AHH! What the heck are you doing in my house! What do you want!" Zarathura screamed panicky.

"I want your head." said Max in a deep gravelly voice.

Max then proceeds to take down Zarathura swiftly. The fight is over.

With his score Max heads back to his house. To Max's luck his house was not overrun by the infected. But it had taken longer to get back to his house because there were more infected than on his way to Zarathura's house.

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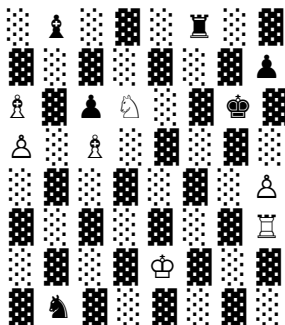
Moves 12-27 · shown at move 20

— Henry Emily —

My left arm has no sense of touch. I sometimes try to pinch myself, which is weird. I haven't ever acted like this... If this escalates, I may have a chance of sleep. I don't want sleep. I have a family. A wife and 2 children. I cannot sleep... not now, not yet.

Chapter 5

The Slow Sleeps



Moves 32-65 · shown at move 40

— Monk —

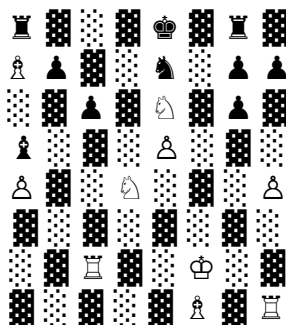
Jocelyn's garden was dark. I took a cutting of the purple-veined plant and wrapped it in a cloth and walked back to the hospital.

The woman was on the steps. Still sharpening.

I showed her the cutting. I told her the early-stage patients were responding and that I thought this was the cure and that people were sleeping while the physicians argued.

She looked at the cutting. She looked at me. She went back to sharpening.

I wrote it down. Page twelve.



Moves 20-53 · shown at move 27

— Jocelyn —

I experience the new plague in the flesh. As I am having my normal morning walk, I see a vendor on the street vomiting and...dancing? Their body then starts to buckle, they're becoming paralyzed. Frozen on my feet, I can't move, my eyes are stuck on them. It is utterly terrifying.

After what feels like years of standing there, I finally am able to break my gaze and am able to run back home. But on my way back, someone coughing approaches me, cautious, I step back.

"Can I help you?" I ask her.

"P-please h-help me.." She stutters out, approaching me, getting closer.

I panic, I don't know what to do. My only solution is to run. As I'm running home, I see someone on the ground, sleeping. What is going on? I make my way home and immediately get in, shutting the door closed behind me, hoping what I saw was just a nightmare.

In the evening, I decided to take a walk in my garden, maybe it can calm my nerves. The walk was calming, at first, until I heard someone moving near the back wall. I froze. This was how it started with the sick ones — the sounds first, then the shuffling, then the vomiting.

"Who is there?" I called out, grabbing my trowel.

A small shape stood up from behind the herb bed. It was Monk. Dirt on his hands, that journal tucked under his arm.

"Monk, what in the world are you doing in my garden in the dark?"

"I need a sample of this plant." He was crouched over the patch near where they found the Queen. The soil was still stained there. "The one with the purple veins."

"That is the plant that took Jerrica."

"That is the plant Jerrica found," he said. Not correcting me exactly. But not agreeing either. He pulled a small cutting carefully, like he was handling something precious, and wrapped it in a cloth.

"You are trespassing in my garden at night to steal a weed that took the Queen. You understand how that sounds."

"I understand how it sounds." He tucked the cutting into his journal. "Thank you, Jocelyn. I will not bother your garden again."

"See that you do not. And Monk—"

He turned.

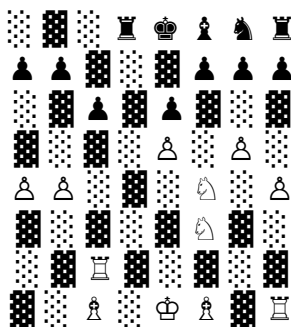
"If anyone asks, you were never here. I do not need people thinking I am helping the talking monkey who thinks he can cure the plague with a weed."

He nodded and slipped out through the back gate. Strange creature. I went back inside and locked the door. The spot where the Queen slept was dark and quiet and I tried not to look at it.

Working in the garden the next day I noticed some of the plants near the back wall had been

trampled. One of them was torn halfway out of the soil, like someone had pulled a piece off and left the rest. There was a stain on the ground nearby that I did not want to look at too closely. I pulled weeds around it and kept working.

. . .



Moves 17-29 · shown at move 20

— Kerian —

Kerian has yet again offended the king. It wasn't his fault. Well it was, or he wouldn't have been put in the dungeon again. He had followed the book that the guard, who Kerian had figured out his name is Alex, brought him. He may have gone off script with a joke.

He has no idea when he'll get out of the dungeon this time. It'll definitely be longer than last time due to a double offense. Alex hasn't been on watch duty yet. Honestly Kerian hasn't seen him around the castle whatsoever. Maybe Alex got executed for sharing food with a peasant when the terrible food is supposed to add to the punishment to those in the dungeon.

A guard, who looks sick and is coughing a lot, finally brings down food to him. It's barely filled.

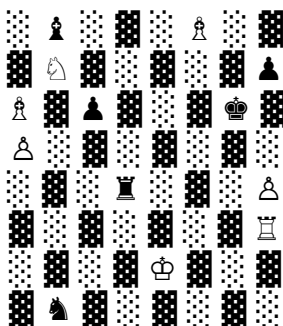
One piece of grey chicken, a bread roll that's moldy, and a bit of water. The water is tinted a gross brownish green. He chokes down the chicken. He doesn't want to eat the roll since it's moldy but he will be left here in the dungeon longer so he chokes it down too. He sips the water.

It tastes like it's from a toilet. The usual for water he receives in the dungeon.

A guard told another guard the Queen was sleeping. "Good riddance," the first one said. "Ate some plant in a garden and dropped to sleep. And you know who found her? That monkey. Sitting there trying to tell everyone the plant didn't take

her. Like he's a doctor now." They both laughed. Kerian sat in the corner and thought at least someone tried.

. . .



Moves 22-44 · shown at move 44

— Robert Topala —

Day 15 of the plague The virus spreads further, vomit is found on the streets every so often. Robert gets a combat trainer since he was immortal before being sent to earth (no need to fight) and he also trains his magic skills, though it's dark magic now.

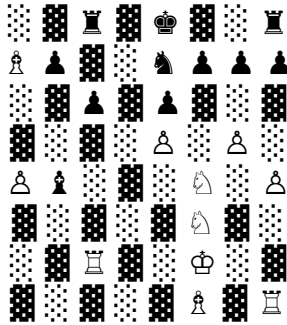
Robert: "Can I take a break now, my arms sore againnnnnn"

Trainer: "No, push yourself"

Robert: *mumbles* "You try falling over 50 ft and tell me how it is"

Just outside someone vomits, still twitching. "Should we be concerned about this?" Robert asks his trainer. "No idea," the trainer replies.

...



Moves 17-29 · shown at move 23

— Kerian —

Today Kerian's stomach has been aching, definitely some weird stomach bug. The culprit may be the bread or that sick guard. The past few days of being down in the dungeon Kerian has been experiencing some weird symptoms of something, it doesn't seem to be the normal stomach issues. His eyes have been twitchy, his hands are shaky and it's been making it hard to eat the food or read the book a guard dropped off and said it was from his friend Alex. Today and the day before his right arm has been uncontrollably moving like a ghost is jerking it around, he hasn't been very hungry despite not having filling meals.

His throat has been aching from how much he's been coughing. Kerian has looked at his hand a few times after bad coughing fits and his hand has had marinara on it. He's been feeling really sick.

Maybe the dungeon hasn't been cleaned and some sick person was in here and made it dirty.

A few hours of sitting and tossing his balls at the wall later he is let out by one of the guards.

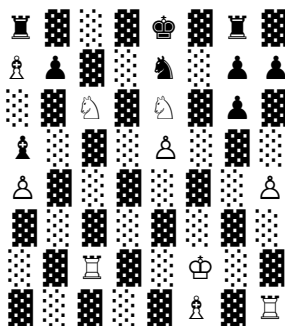
The guard aggressively takes him out of the dungeon and shoves him out the door. Kerian doesn't take his usual route through the forest to get home, he takes the route that passes by the medic's hut. He runs there, despite coughing more and wheezing due to asthma, he reaches the medic's hut. He explains his symptoms to the medic, the medic says he's being over dramatic and says it's a stomach bug.

Kerian disagrees with the medic but heads home anyways. Once he arrives, he takes off his hat, putting the balls into it and removing his shoes. He heads to the bathroom and takes a shower. The warm water washes away the pain. The water runs over his scars, reminding him about what he's been through and where he is

now. Despite all the pain and annoyances of being a jester, he still is glad that he is in a better place than he was as a kid.

He finishes washing up and takes his pajamas off of the clothing line outside, he lays in bed and sleeps. The small sword toy on the windowsill.

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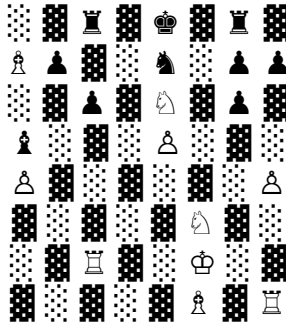
Moves 12-27 · shown at move 27

— Henry Emily —

I'm gonna sleep. I've been vomiting, and my body has been having a second mind of its own recently. I don't know why. I'm holding in the urge to hug this guy on the street... someone, help... please... I can barely talk and write. It's getting worse, too. I wanna live. I can't fight the urge to hug him. This is goodbye, I guess. I can barely fight the urge. The struggle is getting out of hand more and more. Goodbye, dear friend.

— Henry

. . .



Moves 17-29 · shown at move 26

— Kerian —

Kerian decides to stay home today so he can avoid getting into trouble accidentally, again, and also not get the king or queen sick. He spends the day cooking up some soup for himself, maybe some of the townsfolk if they trust him enough to cook.

He simmers some of his tomatoes, potatoes, and carrots. He cooks some chicken. He puts them into the pot with water in it once they are all done cooking, he puts in some cut celery and herbs fresh from his garden.

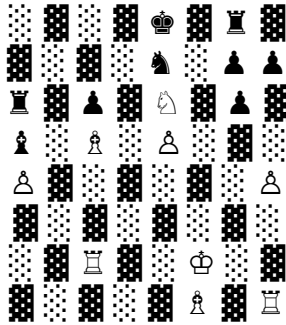
A few hours later the food is done soup-ifying. He puts some into a bowl using the ladle he hand

carved while waiting. He cut himself a few times when doing so. He just wrapped it with strips from an old t-shirt.

As he sips the broth of the soup, it's extremely hot mind you, it still tastes better than food in the dungeon. His throat feels soothed as he eats it. It's been sore from all the coughing. As he's eating, he feels like he's going to puke. He rushes to his bathroom, he luckily makes it into the toilet in time.

"Why does this happen...this seriously isn't some silly stomach bug. Stupid medic. You're supposed to heal people, not let them get sicker." He mutters to himself.

...



Moves 17-29 · shown at move 29

— Kerian —

Despite being much much sicker, Kerian is practically paralyzed, well he can't make his own movements. He's practically dancing, his head is hurting like crazy. Is he going insane?! His body leads him outside, heading to town.

"Nonononono not town?! Are you crazy, you stupid body?!?!?" He thinks to himself, at least he can think for himself.

He pukes into the fountain as he dances around it. He does so a few times, he coughs towards people. His magic is also acting crazy. He's randomly causing vines and plants to grow.

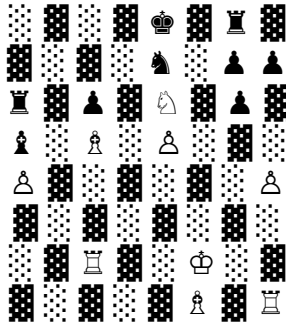
Sprouting seeds from his hands at people. He's using way too much mana. This isn't good. His mana pool is practically empty. His body doesn't stop. He collapses from exhaustion, his body still moving on the ground. Each magic move hurts him due to not having any more mana left.

He then feels a sharp pain in his side. There is a warm pool spreading across his body. Is it finally over? Is the disease gone? He manages to look. The pool is dark red. Red as in marinara.

He's been taken down. He looks to his side, he sees him. His old friend. Major Potato.

"Th-thank you...in case I don't see you again...if I sleep...—good afternoon, good evening, and good night..Major Potat—" He's cut off by sleep taking him. His body lies limp on the ground, head tilting to the side, eyes lay open, lifeless. Parents shield their kid's eye from the horror in front of them.

...



Moves 29-47 · shown at move 29

— Major Potato —

Days 1-28 of the Plague: I learned that during the plague, people had split into two groups. One group believed that there was a cure and worked tirelessly to find it, and the other group thought that there was no cure and tried to sacrifice everybody. I sided with the first group, as did my friends Max, Xanthos, Robert Topala, Jerrica, Henry Emily, and Monks. In the second group, there were people whom I knew or were close with, such as Kerian, Stormy, Zarathura, Kizzlefitch, Jocelyn, Rowan, and Yu.

I am still really afraid of the plague, and I stay indoors at all times. I still have a ton of food to

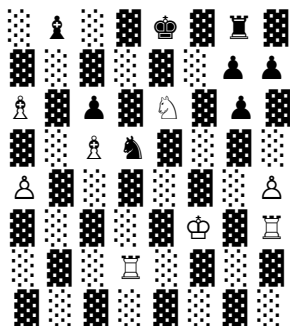
sustain me. However, I realize, sooner or later, I will have to go outside and get more supplies. I decide to go and get supplies the next day. As I stay inside, I hear stuff from outdoors. On the 14th day, Stormy slept. On the 16th day, Jerrica slept. On the 17th day, Kizzlefitch slept. On the 19th day, Zarathura slept. On the 27th day, Henry Emily slept. I heard that for some, citizens passed it to them. For others, they slept after they caught it, and somebody sacrificed them to put them out of their misery.

Stormy was sacrificed by Xanthos after Stormy tried to sacrifice Xanthos. Jerrica slept after searching for a cure in Jocelyn's garden. Kizzlefitch was sacrificed after a citizen who was a sympathizer with the cure-seeking faction assassinated her. Zarathura was sacrificed by Max after Zarathura took an attempt on Max's life. Henry Emily was sacrificed after a citizen who had the plague passed it on to him.

Day 29 of the Plague: I left the house today. As I was walking to the market to buy food, I stopped at the central fountain. I saw a man dancing and vomiting at the same time. I realized he had the plague.

Feeling bad, I went up to him and tried to help him, but he lunged at me. I had to defend myself.

. . .



Moves 20-53 · shown at move 33

— Jocelyn —

I told myself I would not go outside for a while. I lied. The next morning I am in the garden picking at annoying weeds ruining my garden. The sun is beaming at me, making me sweat like a pig, just like Rowan. Honestly, there should be no cure, whoever gets infected should sleep.

"These darn weeds, they're a pain."

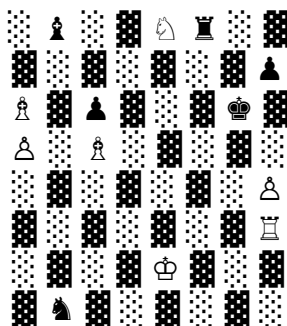
As I'm working, from a distance I see someone who is standing suddenly fall. I can only assume it's the plague.

After working for a while, I go to take a break and get some water by the river, when I suddenly see someone at the bank pinching himself. I rushed over to him, concerned. As soon as I get there, he immediately gets up and starts dancing.

"Help me! Help," he shouts.

I scramble backwards as fast as I can, trying to get away. He keeps on dancing, it looks like he can't stop. He must have the plague. I sprint back to our cottage, maybe some time in the garden can put my mind off of what I saw.

Marinara on the Streets



Moves 20-53 · shown at move 40

— Jocelyn —

I work for a few hours and it's almost evening now, and dinner has to be made. I look around the garden and see that I can make tomato soup. That would be really nice after today, I pick the nice, ripe tomatoes and head inside.

The scent of tomatoes fills the kitchen, the soup in the pot steaming. I set the soup into two bowls, one for me, one for Rowan.

"Rowan, come eat," I call out. Per usual, she doesn't respond, probably has a nose in the book.

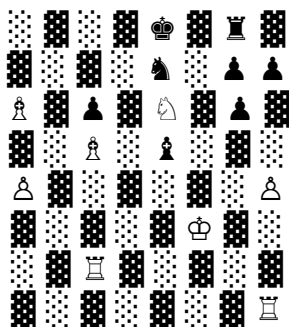
I take a seat and have my nice dinner.

I woke up feeling sick, I kept on coughing and my hands kept shaking. It must be nothing but a normal cold, I'll be fine. My day goes as it usually does, my morning walk and then I tend to the garden for the rest of the day, before making some more tools for Rowan to sell. As I was on my way to Yu's shop to buy The Fae's watering can, because it is extremely helpful, I saw someone just barely crawling towards me. Her face looked pale and her body looked uncontrollable. She continued inching toward me as I continued to back up at the same time. She was getting too close, so I shoved her away and ran. No watering can for me anymore, unfortunately.

A few hours later.

When I got home after that incident, I decided to make some food, fresh from my garden. A salad sounded really nice. As I picked the vegetables, they looked a bit weird, it looked like some tiny spots, but it should be no big deal, I'll just wash it off. After dinner, the rest of the evening was the same and I headed to bed.

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Moves 16-38 · shown at move 31

— Max —

Day 31 of the virus.

"Man that was exhausting," Max mumbles to himself as he flops on his bed. He's been running house to house looking for food but he was only able to find enough food for a week. He took a quick power nap but was instantly bored. After being in his house for 16 days straight at the beginning Max already went through all the different things he could do. So he decided to do the only right thing, traumatize an infected person. So in the dead of night Max found an infected to start traumatizing. Since this one was barely taken over it still had some human in it. He

was quick with his feet so he was able to sneak right up to them and made sure there was no way he would get infected. So for the entire night Max traumatized the infected. He was making them go crazy. Max would just sneak up behind them, stare at them then whisper "I'm always watching you" then he would jump away scaring the living daylights out of them. He kept on doing this until day 33. By then the infected was trembling uncontrollably on the ground, whimpering. Max just stood there wondering if he did that or that was one of the symptoms.

Day 33 of the virus.

After two days of traumatizing the infected Max got bored so he started wandering around not minding the infected out and about. Then that's when a messenger comes running up to Max panting and being chased by the infected. Max immediately grabs the messenger and jumps onto a nearby balcony. As the infected passed the messenger handed Max a letter. Then the messenger casually climbed down from the balcony like he wasn't just chased by an infected horde of people. Max was dumbfounded.

"First you come here being chased by an infected, I save your life and all you hand me is a letter. A LETTER! No thank you, nothing just noting I risked my life for you and this is all you have! Geez!" Max hollered as the messenger walked off.

When Max finally calmed down a bit he ripped open the letter and saw a bounty picture and note saying "Eliminate this human and you will get the reward of 20,000 gold coins." Max realized he would be rich if he completed this task. Yet something felt off as he started to look for this person.

Day 34 of the virus.

Max started on his way to the target. He was only given a brief and vague vicinity the target would be in. On his way Max noticed there weren't as many infected as there were where he lived. As he started to see more people he let his guard down more and more. That's when he stumbled across an inn. Since Max had been traveling for most of the day he was exhausted and could go for some magic strawberries. As he walked into the inn he saw that everyone was big and muscular. But that was the moment he almost squished a

garden gnome to sleep.

"Hey what's the big idea!" said the garden gnome.

Most of the people in the inn froze.

"My bad, sorry I didn't mean to," Max said in a softer voice than normal.

"Sorry isn't gonna cut it buddy. You're gonna need to pay in marinara," the garden Gnome said in a cold expression.

Max stood there confused, wondering how a creature under two feet could hug him.

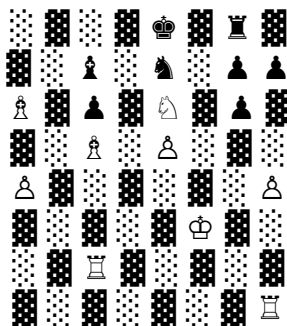
"Yeah right. Like you can get a scratch on me," Max said unamused.

The garden Gnome was getting as red as a ripe tomato. Then she started kicking and punching at Max's shins. Max was obviously annoyed but tried to keep calm and composed. As Max walked off to get a room for the night the Gnome was still spewing remarks at him. Then everything calmed down as Max went upstairs. As soon as he hit the bed he was out.

Day 35 of the virus.

After a decent sleep Max was off again hunting his bounty. He was traveling through a forest when he got this terrible feeling he was being watched. But he just ignored it and continued on his journey. He was nearing the town the target was supposedly seen at when he heard a russell in the bush right next to him. He immediately drew his scythes for protection. Then Max heard something scurrying away in the direction he first heard the sound. He was feeling uneasy and more anxious and jumpy than normal. He was drawing his scythes at the smallest sounds in the forest. But Max felt a sudden relief when he got to the edge of the forest. He started full on sprinting to the edge of the forest. Max finally made it to the edge of the forest but to his surprise it was already turning dark. Max was hurriedly walking around trying to find a place to stay when he found another inn. So this time being extra careful he made his way to his room and crashed.

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Moves 25-50 · shown at move 30

— Yu —

Yu wakes up inside of his wagon. It's quite spacious, being able to fit a shorter man like himself.

There are a bunch of boxes and crates holding several things like potions, arrows, bows, swords, gold, artifacts, anything that you can think of. He gets up with a bit of a bed head, some hair sticking up and his eyes are half opened. Yu changes into his daily clothes, a brown short sleeve with a wrap around his arms along with a blue scarf with yellow-gold diamond patterns embroidered onto it. He goes outside with his big backpack. Today is resource gathering day.

As Yu walks outside the kingdom's gates, he takes out his list of materials to gather; luminescent moss, large puffball mushrooms, onyx flower essence, elder tree sticks, and purple pear fruit. What a pain, Yu starts to think, but the gold... he tries to convince himself to work, as he does every day. While foraging for materials early in the morning, Yu sees a wandering mercenary. She is strange and unsettling, seemingly also foraging for materials but something about her...

Hurk- Yu has a putrid smell enter his already sensitive nose and he immediately covers it with his bandana-scarf. "What the-" He whispers to himself. She didn't seem to hear Yu but her movements seem painful and forced yet as graceful as a dance..? At this sight Yu is clearly frightened but as he goes to turn around a gross "BLEHHHHH" fills the area. He turns his head curious at the sound as sees her collapsed on the grass with throw up everywhere. It is truly a horrendous sight for this money hungry man. Yu does not know how to react to this information that he just saw and decided to take his stuff and run back to the kingdom. *Was that a zombie?

No... can't be. Undead aren't able to move during the day. Ugh, I don't like this place anymore* Yu frantically thinks as he reaches the gates, looking scared.

"HALT!" The guards have changed shifts and the new one seems scarier than the last. "What business do you have in Chromyre?" He asks skeptically, most likely thinking Yu was some sort of thief.

"Wait- *huff* I think someone SLEPT- *huff* They just-" Yu frantically tries to relay his information to the guard but Yu just ran without conserving stamina and now he's out of breath. He shakes his head and tries to catch his breath.

"Pardon?" The guard looks a bit more worried now but he is still skeptical.

"No, I'm a merchant. Here's my badge." Yu fumbles around a bit and takes out his merchant's guild badge.

"Yeah... okay." The guard lets Yu scramble into the gates and hurriedly goes to his wagon to jot everything down into his journal. *THIS PLACE IS FREAKY— I mean, someone just* Yu's hands are shaking and terrified of what he has just seen and

he is unable to write down what he feels. *I NEED to tell someone about this... yeah... but this is only the fourth time I've been here.* His thoughts run wild and he ruffles his hair trying to figure out what to do. *What even WAS that?* Yu opens his many books on things and tries to find similar cases in his books.

"Kidney pox, horn chroma, feathered warts, shadow terrorism..." flipping through all of these has been as helpful as him looking at the girl collapse onto the ground.

"UGH! None of these books have ANYTHING!" Yu yells in frustration, he loves being in the know of everything but the mystery of that girl would haunt him. "I-I need to go out there and collect information... myself."

Yu grabs his gear; a stamina artifact, a mana artifact, a short sword, gloves, and courage. As he meets the gates for the 3rd time today, he shakes his head, trying to understand why he would actually do this. *I'm doing this because...* He has to think a bit but before he is able to come up with an answer, he has already arrived at the body. It is eerily still but he doesn't want to believe it. The putrid smell isn't as bad this time for he has

covered his nose again but it's a sweetly sickly smell. It's acidic like stomach acid yet metallic like— "She's leaking marinara out of her mouth..." Yu doesn't want to touch her but he takes a sample of her marinara. "Should I get help...?"

"You there." A dark raspy voice calls behind scaring Yu.

"AH! I mean uh- yes?" Yu turns around slowly, raising his hands as if he did something wrong.

"What are you doing?" The question sounded like a demand to spit out everything Yu knew.

"I- uhm- uh-hh" Yu starts sweating bullets, scared to respond, not knowing the 'right' answer to respond with.

"..." A black cloak, draping this mysterious voice, waits for an answer.

"He's too unpredictable and looks dangerous... one wrong move and I could end up like HER!" Yu thinks as he tries to come up with a good answer. "Well, what d-does it look like to you?"

"You hugged her?"

"OH! Uhm, no! Of course not, heh."

"Then what are you doing?"

"I'm uhmm, collecting data...?" His response comes out stronger than he feels.

"I see-" The mysterious figure coughs hard and he lifts his hood. A mars black dragonborn stands in front of Yu.

"Who are you..?"

"No one important."

"Oh ok." Yu is a bit relieved to have a face for this mysterious voice and decides to make an excuse to leave. "I need to go... hahah.." He chuckles nervously then runs back to the gates and enters his wagon just in time to open shop. While taking care of the customers, he starts having cracks in his facade of trying to act like everything is normal. He starts like: "Hello! Welcome to the shop of wonders! How may I help you today?"

But starts deteriorating to: "Hell-o! Ahaha... uhm- welcome to my shop! Do you need anything?"

With several nervous chuckles sprinkled about. This is quite unusual for this master merchant, him being able to sell a rusted sword for a piece of gold to struggling to find the right words to use in

simple sales.

At the end of the day Yu is drained from people, all the events crashing about and he finally has time to 'unwind' per se. He takes out the small sample of marinara he collected from the woman and thoughts of it make him feel ill. *What are you going through?* He casts a few spells to test the samples but nothing much comes back. *High acid... ugh, low marinara sugar..? Maybe.* Yu thinks about what this thing is and if it's common. *I need to ask someone tomorrow.* The new day starts, Yu wakes up in a cold sweat having had an awful sleep the night before. He gets ready again for the new day; shirt, pants, belt, scarf, arm wraps, and his sword. Stepping outside feels a bit scary, knowing that most people are oblivious to this thing that he witnessed the day prior. "Was that a disease? Is it common here?" When Yu starts thinking about it, several thoughts rush into his head making it harder for him to figure out who to ask.

After thinking about it for some more time, he remembers a few certain prodigies in Idmere. A pair of gnomes who just so happen to be around this area. "I'll pay them a visit after breakfast."

Yu decides as he steps into a nearby inn but then sees the mysterious black dragonborn from yesterday eating some food. "Hey! Aren't you the guy from yesterday?" Yu asks as he approaches the table.

"Hm?" The black dragonborn responds curiously.

"We never fully chatted, hahaaa.." Yu nervously chuckles remembering that this guy is a bit scary.

"Do you need something?"

"Yeah, uhm, I'd like to ask about yesterday." Yu says as he sits in front of the dragonborn. "But first, what is your name?" He tries again to know who he's talking to.

"Max." His demeanor seems different from yesterday's. A bit more casual and not on edge.

"So Max, I'd like to ask about what we saw yesterday." Yu tries to act lax and not as stressed as he truly is. He looks at the waiter and waves him over to order some food first. "Pardon that interaction, but did you see the girl 'dance' a bit before she collapsed?"

"No." Max replies in short direct answers making Yu question everything. After the food arrives Yu finishes up and tries to get more details from Max.

"Do you know or have any speculations on what is occurring?"

"No" Max answers then starts coughing again. From Yu's view, he can only see what could be assumed as dragon's marinara that was hacked up.

"Are you ok?"

"Presumably."

"Oh, ok, yeah." Yu sees that the colour is a bit similar to the girl's marinara. A deep blue color with red specks. *Is it contagious?* Is the thought that runs through his head. "Well it was nice chatting with you Max, but I'm going to take my leave. Farewell." Yu says before he could respond a bit scared that either of them could now be infected.

"I should most likely go get some gifts before I arrive unannounced to their house." Yu thinks to himself as he goes back to his wagon. He goes to grab some plant seeds and a few snacks such as;

Dried mangos, special candied grapefruit skin, salted fried fish, and a few freshly picked fruits. The walk to the gnomes house was a short one, the only thing that made it take longer was Yu's courtesy to walk instead of run in such a public area with shorter civilians.

Ding dong! A bell noise rings as Yu enters the door.

"Hello!" A voice calls out from under. Rowan. A short orange haired gnome greets Yu. She has a messy white shirt with a pair of overalls on but one side isn't clipped.

"Hi hi." Yu greets back as he takes out his basket of goods. "I've brought you guys some gifts."

"Thank you, Yu," another voice calls out. One more mature and stoic. There is another gnome, she has black midlength hair and a green dress with a dark brown corset.

"I'm pondering something and I was wondering if you guys knew anything about this," Yu starts as he takes out the marinara sample in his pocket. "The other day, I was foraging for some plants but there was this girl and she was 'dancing'..." He

realizes that he probably sounds like some sort of crazy person.

"Dance? Weird." Rowan says, clearly judging this girl.

"She looked like she was in pain as well but before I was able to ask, she collapsed onto the ground." Yu closes his eyes a bit disgusted at remembering the image he saw that day. It was a brief flash before he turned away but it was still a morbid sight.

"Her body was contorted by the time I came back to collect samples... Ah right, my questions.

Have you guys seen any cases like this previously?"

"I think it's a new plague that has developed recently. There have been a few cases and the things you described sound just like it." Jocelyn replies in some deep thought. "No cure has been found yet though."

"Genuinely..?" Yu looks nervously around and puts his scarf up as a feeble defense. "I-I'll take my leave now." He bows down a bit then exits the door thinking deeply about the fact that there's no cure. *"Haha... Does that mean something like that*

could happen to me?" Then a strike of brilliance comes to him. *"I could start working on the formula and sell it. I could make a monopoly!"* Yu nods to himself in this genius, trying to see the 'good' in this chaos that he sees.

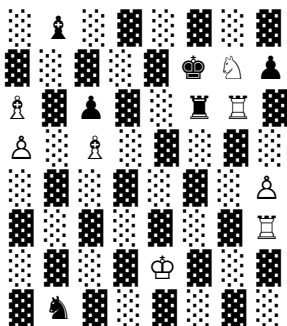
The rest of the day flies by in a blur, he spends it by studying the marinara sample and mixing all sorts of materials together. Testing it on the marinara again and again, he has created other cures before but this one was testier and way too hard to understand. The worst imaginable thought then crosses his mind, *What if there actually isn't a cure?* It's an awful feeling, but what makes it worse is the fact that he also wasted so many ingredients, including some of the blue mushrooms. Those had the most effect per se and he decided to include that.

After the long day finally concluded, Yu goes to take a stroll outside in the city. Several species congregate and walk freely, most of them unaware of the plague infecting the kingdom. He doesn't look where he is going, just thinking and walking mindlessly, trying to calm down so he is able to sleep in peace. *Splat* A warm liquid touches Yu's hoof. It's disgusting and putrid,

having the same smell as the girl before.

"What the-" Yu quickly looks down and sees Max, lying on the ground, sleeping. Yu quickly goes to cover his nose with his scarf and goes to wash off the marinara that he stepped in. "T-that wasn't Max was it? Haha.. who am I kidding! Of course not... yeah..." Yu quietly mutters to himself, genuinely wondering for a bit and trying to ignore it. "Must've been someone else you know, yeah..." The thought of seeing two people already sleep makes Yu on edge, knowing that he has been in close proximity so he may also have it. After washing off again Yu sits in his wagon, candles lit up and thoughts running, running faster than he could ever run.

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Moves 16-38 · shown at move 38

— Max —

Day 38 of the virus.

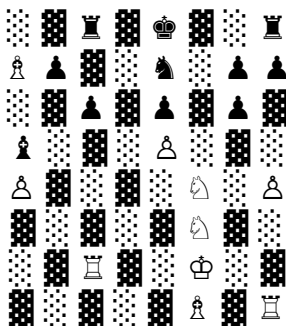
Max grogily wakes up and has a minor panic attack when he doesn't recognize where he is but then it clicks that he was in an inn. Max had been so tired from everything that was happening in Chromyre. Max quickly left the inn so he wouldn't be charged for an overstay. As soon as Max got a good distance away from the inn he pulled out the bounty poster and began asking around if anyone saw his target. Then some people said they saw him by an old bridge at the edge of town. Max thought he might not be there by now but it was worth a shot. So Max set out on another trip

through town.

After a while he was just about to reach the bridge when it started to become dark. Once again he had a bad feeling about this but due to the amount of money he was going to receive he pushed on. He looked around the bridge and surprisingly saw a man that matched the bounty Max was looking for. He slowly drew his blades preparing to strike. But saw that the man was motionless. Max slowly approached the man to see if he was alive then with one explosive movement the man tried poking Max in the solar plexus with a small dagger but due to his scales Max was unharmed but for the man he was messed up badly. Firstly Max disarmed him then made the bounties sleep a slow and agonizing one for what he had tried to do. But as Max was about to leave there was a sharp exploding pain in his chest.

Max looked down and to his shock there was a short sword poking his chest with marinara slowly trickling down his chest. His vision started to blur. Max started swaying back and forth, losing consciousness by every second. Then everything went black.

...



Moves 1-60 · shown at move 25

— Rowan —

"I think we have to go sell in order to make a living," Jocelyn commented. "I think it's time since we have been inside for the past week."

We ate breakfast and I set out again to Indmere. Lately it has been colder than usual and today was no different. The sharp gusts of wind gave me an unsettling feeling especially since few people were on the street. As I entered the town square I was hyperfocused, learning from my previous mistakes. I performed my usual preparations, with my only hope being to walk home with money.

"What are you selling?" a stranger asked with excitement, youth, and warmth in their voice.

"Um...lots of stuff really, why don't you take a look." I said casually.

She looked around my cart for a little while innocently while I read the newspaper Jocelyn showed me earlier.

"You know I just can't believe there is really a plague here in Chromyre," I said, still in shock about it.

"I kno-" she tried to respond.

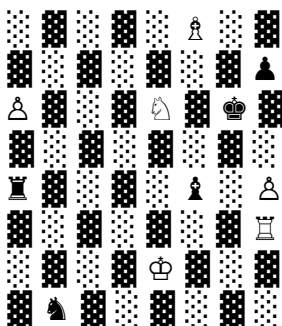
Suddenly before she could finish, she collapsed to the floor. I tried to help her up as soon as I processed what just happened. I went to smack her awake but before I struck her, her eyes opened ominously. I jumped back in fear. She got up in a threatening way and started charging me. I ran hard in the opposite direction. I looked back to see how much of a lead I had on this young girl. As soon as I looked back she faceplanted into the ground and was eerily still. I walked up to her slowly because I didn't know if she would get up again. Could this have been the plague? No because it happened to quick, she wasn't

coughing or dancing, right? I reached where she was and checked her pulse. She was indeed sleeping.

I could have run. I could have gone home. I could have done so many things but all I did was sit there and cry. I cried for so long. What has my life come to? I sat there and cried.

Chapter 7

The Merchant of Sleep



Moves 32-65 · shown at move 49

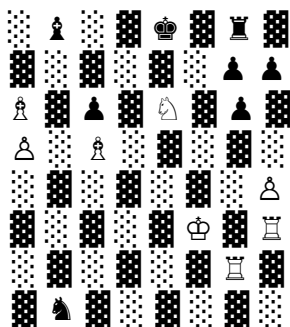
— Monk —

Yu sent me away again and I walked back to the hospital with my dried leaf and I wrote it down.
Page thirty-one.

The woman was on the steps. I sat down next to her because my feet hurt.

She did not tell me to leave.

We sat there for a while.



Moves 25-50 · shown at move 35

— Yu —

A new day, again. Yu is already starting to overthink everything, trying to figure out a cure to the plague was already out of the question, yet he has already spent so many ingredients that he now needs to earn back the loss. "I should make something that works a bit at least." Yu thinks to himself. He gets changed into his usual shirt and pants with his scarf and starts mixing his cauldron again. *Those blue mushrooms from the other day, they did well.* Yu thinks as he goes outside to the inn again. He walks to a table of 1 and orders his breakfast. *Where did I find those again...?* The thought that he had completely forgotten to write down the location is one that he doesn't want to think of at the moment while he enjoys his food.

After eating, Yu grabs one of the mushrooms to know its scent so he can collect more. Walking outside the gates of the kingdom, being wary of others to not get infected, he sees a yellow minion at her post. She seems to be on watch duty. Now with the scent in mind, Yu goes out running to get to the area quicker. When he arrives. The air smells just like the mushroom, absolutely disgusting. He gets to collect them and stores them inside of his bag.

For the next 3 hours, Yu marks off everything that he'll need for his 'cure' and quickly goes back to the kingdom to open shop again. When he arrives, his cauldron is still full with his 'cure' that he has made. After filling up a few bottles, Yu opens the shop again. The rest of the day goes as usual with some arguments against customers that go along the lines of: "What!? These prices are insane! Are you scamming me??" The customer would ask, or argue trying to haggle everything down.

"No, I picked and crafted all of those by myself, guaranteed!" Yu would respond trying to keep the peace.

Things went like that for a bit, one with a centaur, another with the minion with the bow, and another with a random civilian. These were the types of people that Yu was always irritated with, having to breathe in and out to keep himself calm and not buckle under the pressure of everything happening around him already.

Monk came to the shop carrying his journal and a dried leaf. "I need more of these. The ones with purple veins. I have been testing them at the hospital and the early-stage patients are responding. Their tremors decrease within hours. I just need a larger supply to—"

"I sell potions, Monk. Not weeds. And I do not give out supplies for free."

"People are sleeping, Yu."

"People have been sleeping for weeks, Monk. That is not new information." Yu waved him off. The monkey stood there holding his leaf for another moment. Then he left. Strange creature. Always treating an emergency like it is something you can solve with enough patience.

After the day ends, there is one final customer.

"Hello Major Potato! Welcome back! Today we have some new things like a cure to the plague!"

Yu said, trying to maintain his calm near the general.

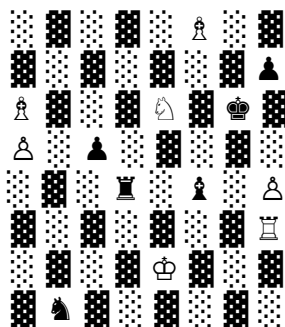
"Hello Yu. May I get one of those?" Major Potato asks, he is the centaur general of the army and has many scars.

"Of course, here you go. 1 gold." Yu knows that this is heavily overpriced but it is the first of its kind to come out so far.

"1 whole gold? Expensive much, hah."

"Well, it did take me a lot to collect these things." Yu chuckles along too and waves farewell to the general. A pretty decent day but Yu still can't get over the thoughts of Max lying on the ground in a pool of marinara and vomit with that putrid smell. He closes up shop and gets ready to sleep, too scared to exit at night in fear of what's to come.

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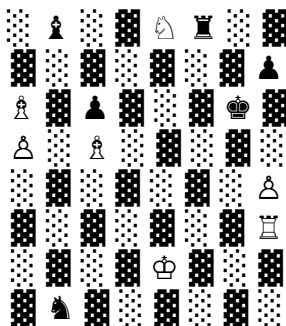
Moves 20-53 · shown at move 46

— Jocelyn —

When I woke up in the morning, I felt even worse. My left arm couldn't move, that was really weird. What could I have done? I can't possibly have the plague, can I? I felt deeply unsure and antsy, there was no cure for the plague yet, and I am against it. Still, I got up and started my day. Throughout the rest of my day, I wasn't very hungry at all, maybe I just had a lot of food yesterday. I tried to work in the garden, but with only one arm able to move, it was extremely challenging, so I gave it a break and rested. I tried to eat but I didn't feel hungry.

In the evening, I decided to do some work in the garden. I have not been feeling well. I've felt terrible. After working in the garden for a long time, I went to bed.

...



Moves 25-50 · shown at move 40

— Yu —

A new day. A secret wish to not be here. Yu gets up once more for a new day. Outside is cloudy with a chance of raining and it has been a few weeks since Yu sold the 'cure' out to several people. His money was at an all time high and his mental was— "WONDERFUL!" Yu exclaims as he looks outside. He's seen several other people drop to sleep by now with the disgusting sight and almost everything smells putrid. Today outside was no different, 'positivity' was the right answer to Yu. *Everything will come and pass, I shouldn't change their fate but hasten it.* These nonsensical words were the thing that Yu has come to realize

as he starts putting drops of poison in his cure. The people were flocking to his stall and he started documenting down what happens in all victims of the plague, telling people his findings; During the first stage, you'll start coughing and twitching. During the second stage, you'll experience not being able to control your body and stomach pain, during the third stage you'll start vomiting and 'dancing', finally at the fourth stage you'll lose control of your body and 'dance' until you drop. This information was spread about and is now referred to as The Ephemeral Choreomania.

A centaur then approaches, a familiar scarred face.

"Hello Major Potato." Yu welcomed him with the sly of a fox.

"Yu... I don't think the cure is working." Major Potato says weakly.

"Well, I can assure you that it should be! Unless if it.." Yu wanders off thinking why it hasn't traded off Major potato yet.

"Yu... you scum." He coughs a bit trying not to throw up and control his body movement for it has

been a few weeks since he began having choreomania.

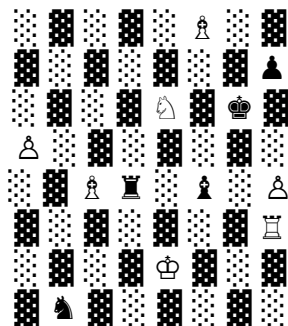
"I beg your pardon?" Yu looks a bit stunned at the words and looks at Major Potato.

"I-I'll expose you for thi-*Hurk*" Major Potato starts coughing up marinara. Yu waltzes over a bit too confident compared to how he thought. He draws his short sword and presses the tip to Major Potato's neck, channeling his mana.

"You won't live to see me 'exposed' Mr. General." Yu looks into Major Potato's eyes, a bit crazed and manic, but goes through the final blow. He lets out a large fire spell that comes from the tip of the sword.

"No need to thank me for the favor." Yu says to the unmoving body that's growing cold and he opens a slip in the fabric of reality, using it to transport Major Potato elsewhere to rot.

...



Moves 29–47 · shown at move 47

— Major Potato —

Day 47 of the Plague: I went to Yu's shop to get supplies. I did not see Yu, so I waited there. I saw somebody slinking in an alley with a dagger drawn, but I did not show any signs of knowing that that person was there. I thought that it was Stormy, but then I remembered that Stormy was sleeping. So I went on guard, waiting for the person to strike. The person leaped, and I turned and deflected it with my sword. I could recognize the person now. It was a man with a sharp kitchen knife drawn. He looked like he was out to take me, so I waited for him to come at me again. He leaped, and I deflected and then poked him right

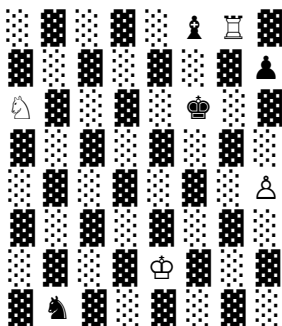
under the blade. He slept on the spot.

Then, Yu arrived. I felt like I was coming down with the plague. I bought a cure for the plague from him. I forgot that he was on the opposing side. This mistake caused my sleep. I drank it, but felt nothing. I bought another and drank it, but I still felt nothing. I grew a bit suspicious, but I bought another. I drank it, but I felt nothing.

I asked Yu, "Does this cure even work?"

Yu grew anxious but did not answer. I told Yu that I would report this to the public. Yu got really scared and angry and whipped out one of his short swords and fired a fire explosion magic. He poked at me, and I was not expecting it, so I got hit. I slept a few seconds later from the explosion and the plague.

. . .



Moves 20-53 · shown at move 53

— Jocelyn —

A week later My health has been declining rapidly, I finally accepted the fact that I had the plague and I would not be surviving. I could no longer control my own body, it controlled itself. One day, I ended up pinching myself because I had no control. I hadn't uttered a word to Rowan about it yet, I can't let her know that I am suffering. I was downstairs with Rowan and we were having a conversation.

"We have to sell more if we want to live," I stated towards Rowan.

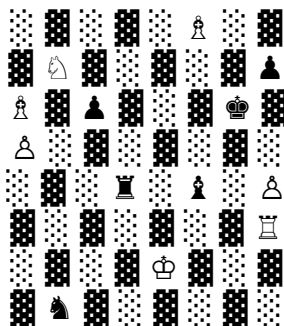
"Okay, I'll head out to Idemere after breakfast," she replied.

After she left, I decided to live my last day in the garden. My health is bad. But then I saw a guy, who supports the cure, named Robert. I have seen him so many times. He thinks that people should deserve a cure and not sleep. He entered my garden to talk about the cure again. I was tired of him, I wanted him to go, so I walked over to him. As he inched towards me I "accidentally" pushed a half-dead tree on him. SQUASH. Finally he was sleeping. I continued my work, ignoring the guy smushed under the tree.

I worked for a bit before I felt worse. I could feel my heart start to thump a little slower, the sky started to look a little grey and smudged, it was dull and sad. My vision tunneled, my hearing starting to turn into static as everything started to fade away. I try to blink it away, I'm fine, right?

The only thing my eyes can pinpoint is the outline of our cottage, our home, until finally I feel nothing as everything I see goes black.

...



Moves 25-50 · shown at move 45

— Yu —

The rest of the day goes as well as any other day. Yu sells things, he sees sleeping bodies, people clean up, he stays in his wagon, and goes outside? He walks out, less terrified of the plague he tried so desperately to eradicate before and finds another soul following him. "Hellooooo?" He calls out.

"..." Silence returns. Yu is able to deduce the fact that this may be a random person but in the next second, a dagger is directed at Yu's neck, having him in a choke hold basically.

"Y-you really hugged Major Potato?" A timid voice says, sounds like one a young man who's in the army. "He was—"

"He was sick." Yu finishes without much fear of sleep, long been tired of living this life but had too much cowardance to admit it.

"NO! He was the bravest and most kind hearted general and, and you just—" Tears could be heard from the other man, not having the courage to end Yu.

"I helped him like any other good friend would do." Yu says, becoming bored of this person's nonsensical word vomit. He strongly kicks the man and knocks him to the ground. "Do you need help? Are you... sick?" Yu draws his sword once more and points it at the chest.

"I-I" The man is in too much fear to respond and tries to scramble away.

"Don't worry, I'm kind and benevolent." Yu says as he plunges down, missing the tomato by a bit and poking the baguette. A loud scream is heard and Yu has a psychotic facial expression, smiling as if he's actually helping someone. "Don't be scared, I'm helping you end your misery." and

with one final blow, Yu ends the other person's life, marinara splattering and giving his clothes some red accents.

A bit dissatisfied with this filth, Yu goes to clean up everything yet the smell of iron remains. The day ends as Yu rolls out his tarp and goes to sleep, calmer than before, desensitized to all the chaos.

A new day, a joyous day. Yu gets out of bed and changes clothes, brushes hair, does the normal and opens shop. Refilling today would be pointless, everyone is already sleeping. Several people still line up though for Yu's 'magical cure'. The placebo that Yu used was quite good, making people think they were changing. Well, they were, but not better. Instead of vomiting violently everywhere, it was more controlled, but in return... their body started producing more stomach acid than usual.

"Yu." Another familiar centaur approaches.

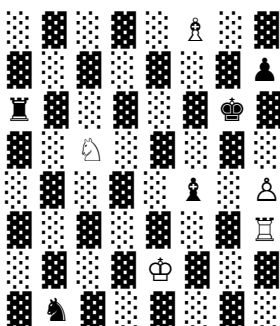
"Hello customer! Do you need something today?"

"Yes." The centaur draws his weapon and without warning pokes it straight into Yu's chest.

"I need you gone." He then goes to turn away, quite anticlimactically trading off Yu.

"Oh." Yu simply lets out before he too collapses onto the floor, simply letting sleep take over him.

. . .



Moves 25-50 · shown at move 50

— Yu —

What happened in the time gap?

The day starts once more, I wake up in my dingy wagon covered in cold sweat. I hate knowing there's no cure but what should I do then? My 'cure' is only a temporary measure for everyone and it barely does much. I need to find a better formula... or is there another way... No, blasphemy.

"Hello! Welcome to my shop of wonders. Feel free to look around." Putting a mask on for customers is so tiring, how do they act so oblivious to this plague spreading everywhere?

"Ahem, Yu, can I get these potions?" A customer asks, She's a young elf with a bit of a scowl, annoyed of waiting.

"Yes, right away Ma'am." I reply trying to not think about the horrors. The rest of the day is like this, and as I walk outside to get some food at the nearby inn I see a familiar sight. A man, 'dancing', moving uncontrollably over the fountain. The moves are as elegant as a swan yet forced like a puppet. He hunches over the fountain, vomits a bit, then twirls around releasing plant magic and making vines grow. They look like they're in pain, too much pain. *Maybe there's another way to stop this plague...* I shake my head a bit, gripping my sword hilt instinctively then letting go to enter the inn.

"One lemonade and classic vegetarian sandwich please, oh, and remove the mushrooms.

Thank you." My food gets ordered and I start eating. The food is great as always but it tastes

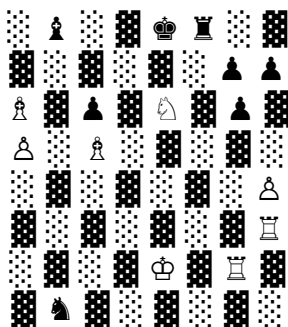
bitter and bland with the days passing by. I should probably leave this kingdom to return but I spent so much time coming here. The thought of leaving this place is a great one but I really needed my profit to be returned... and I'm so generous I'll even share my cure with these unknowing civilians... yes.

After the day ends I lie awake on my bed. It's never the most comfortable but the tarp is at least enough to keep me warm and cozy at night.

Another day starts, it's been a few days, I'm starting to feel more dread as they pass. I've seen at least 13 people sleep now. Ahaha... it's fine though everything's fine here. Sleeping is a normal occurrence and people are already suffering. They must feel like me right? Internal doom wondering when the kingdom will fall apart? Yeah.. yeah... We're all in the same boat haha. I mean, if the world's already going to crumble into ruins, why not hasten the process? That thought was my eureka moment, I knew I was onto something, something wonderful to give others and help them out a bit.

They all want help, right?

...



Moves 1-60 · shown at move 36

— Rowan —

30 minutes later Pulling my cart felt heavier than ever. I made my way down my street with the air weighing down on my shoulders.

"AHHHHHH!" I screamed with my soul.

I dropped to the floor. My whole world just broke in two seconds. Once again, I wept. Jocelyn was sleeping.

I was flat on the ground in a pool of my own tears. The neighborhood was silent with only the wind rustling through the tree branches.

As I lay on the ground I heard small footsteps behind me. I knew it was Monk without looking.

He is always showing up wherever someone sleeps, kneeling down and checking pulses on people who obviously have no pulse left. I heard him kneel beside Jocelyn. I heard him do his breathing check, tilting her chin.

"I brought her medicine last week," he said. "The preparation from the purple plant. She would not take it. She said there was no cure and she would rather sleep in her garden than take false hope from a monkey."

"Get away from her," I said into the dirt.

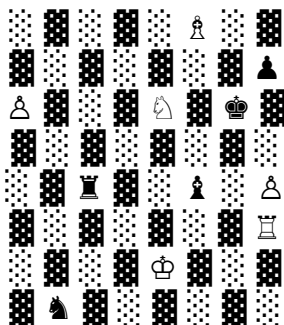
"Rowan, the medicine works. I have seen it work. If she had taken it—"

"I said get away from her."

He went quiet. I heard him close Jocelyn's eyes. Then the small footsteps backed away and were gone.

He tried to save her. I do not care. What good is a cure that nobody believes in.

Everything I See Goes Black



Moves 1-60 · shown at move 48

— Rowan —

One hour later *I can't take this anymore. They should just sleep. All of them. All of the people with this horrible plague, so no more people get infected. If they sleep, the plague sleeps too.* I grabbed my sewing kit and sewed cloths to cover people's mouths, I crafted signs, and I put everything on my cart to go out to the town square but this time with no fear. Most importantly I turned some of Jocelyn and I's tools into weapons,

and put them on my cart.

For the third time this week, I walked into the town square and I prepared my cart and got ready to sell.

"What do you have here?" a customer asked.

"Masks and weapons, are you interested?" I said with hope.

"This is a plague protection stand, right?" the customer said with confusion.

"Yeah, obviously," I replied annoyed.

"Then why do you have weapons?"

"Because we need to rid them of here so they don't infect us," I said like it was common knowledge.

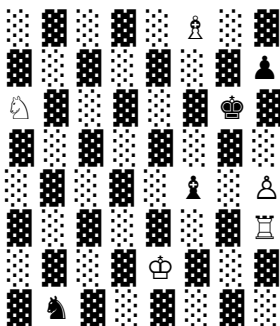
"Why would you do that when we could find a cure?" they replied defiantly.

"It's not worth it, everyone is sleeping and we aren't finding a cure anytime soon."

We went back and forth for a while, but I was making almost inarguable points. Eventually I chose to move my cart to a busier spot. Someone else walks up to my cart curious as to what I am

selling. Very few people are in the town, mostly parents buying food for their children. The man walks up to my stand and only once he gets closer I realize he is aggressively coughing. I step back, but remember I am not scared anymore. I still can't tell who this man is. I grab one of the weapons I made and jam it into his diaphragm. He collapsed to the floor, marinara spilling out. I collected myself and grabbed my cart and walked to another spot.

. . .



Moves 10-50 · shown at move 50

— Xanthos —

It was a complete nightmare for me. All of my friends I knew in the kingdom fell to the plague, or my friends — believing they could not create a cure — sacrificed them, and I— I captured one of them myself. Jerrica fell on the 16th day, Kizzlefitch on the 17th, Zarathura on the 19th, Henry on the 27th, Kerian on the 29th, Max on the 38th, and Major Potato — the greatest blow to me — on the 47th. I captured Yu on the 50th, Robert on the 52nd, then Jocelyn the next day. Soon I started to feel the effects myself. I knew it was the end for me.

On the 57th day, I went to a tree, and I vomited violently in secret, all over, and my body was twitching like crazy, until Rowan and Monk found me after hearing my sounds. Rowan held her long sword cautiously, and the monk stayed back. He was carrying his journal and a small pouch. He always carried that journal. I had seen him around the kingdom with it for weeks, writing things down, talking to people who did not want to listen. I never paid much attention. He was just Monk. The monkey from the market. The one Major Potato was always telling to be quiet.

He was not being quiet now. He was standing very still, looking at me, and I could see him thinking. Like he was reading my symptoms the way he reads his journal.

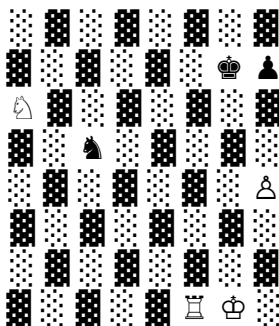
I had the plague, so I have prevented others, so it had to be done. "Put me out of my misery," I finally said. Rowan put down her long sword and poked me. I was still alive, but I knew I was gonna soon.

I looked at Monk. "A cure is possible," I said. "You just need to work hard."

I do not know why I said it to him specifically. Maybe because he was the only one who looked like he believed it. Maybe because he was the only one who had been working at all.

I don't know if they would listen, but they had to. After my final words, I slowly put my head down and closed my eyes, sleeping on the spot.

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Moves 32-65 · shown at move 57

— Monk —

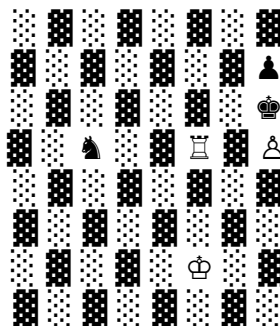
Three days after Xanthos slept Rowan came through the roof and I screamed at her to stop and she did not stop and I picked up a blade and I took her and Sunofa came through the door a moment later and took the blade from my hand and cleaned it and covered Rowan with a sheet and did not say anything.

I went outside and sat on the steps.

She came and sat next to me and went back to sharpening her sword.

I did not write it down.

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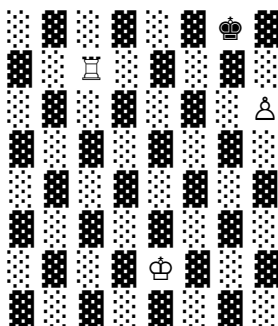


Moves 1-60 · shown at move 60

— Rowan —

Before I could look back at what I had done my vision went blurry. All I could see was a small figure holding a dagger.

The Talking Monkey



Moves 32-65 · shown at move 65

— Monk —

Sunofa said get up so I got up and gave the woman in cot three her dose and fed the man in cot seven and checked the journal. The woman's tremors were gone five days now. The man could move his arm again and he kept doing it over and over and crying about it so I wrote it down.

The plant works if you crush it and get to people early. I proved this.

That night Sunofa told me the plague came in through grain shipments and the King put it there

on purpose and Kizzlefitch found proof of this before she slept and Jerrica found the plant before she slept and I had been writing all of it down the whole time without knowing what it added up to. I said what do we do and Sunofa said you finish the cure and I finish the King so that is what we did.

. . .

There were pages near the back of my journal that I did not write and the handwriting was small and uneven and the ink was a little green and at the top it said a song (probably bad). It was Zarathura's. She was the bard who slept on day nineteen and she had already written a song about the King before any of us knew about the King. The fourth verse stopped in the middle of a line because she did not finish it before she slept.

I told Sunofa we were going to the throne room.

. . .

There were seven people there and the King was already on his knees because Sunofa had been there first. I read the song out loud.

*Our king had a very good plannn
He'd quietly cull as he can
He put plague in the grain
And called it gods rain
Now who's gonna stop that old man*

*There once was a king with a plan
To thin out his people's lifespan
He shipped in the grain
With spores in each vein
And called it all part of gods plan*

***Oh the kingggg
Oh the kingggg
He gave us a gift and it had a stingggg
Oh the kingggg
Oh the kingggg
Everybody danced but nobody singsss
Oh the king***

*A king thought his people too manyyyy
And didn't want to spare them a pennyyyy
He poisoned the wheat
And watched them all tweeeet
Now the kingdom don't got hardly any*

*You ask who would do such a thing
On a whim, on a prayer, and a wing
The people all danced
And nobody glanced
Still don't know? Who but the—*

***Oh the kingggg
Oh the kingggg
He gave us a gift and it had a stingggg***

***Oh the kingggg
Oh the kingggg
Everybody danced but nobody singsss
Oh the king***

*There once was a kingdom that danced
Not because anyone asked
The king said "too manyyyy"
And poisoned the granny
Now nobody's left but the last*

*Who put the plague in the grain?
(The king! The king!)
Who called all our dying gods rain?
(The king! The king!)
Who's sitting up high while we rot in the lane?
The king, the king, the king
The king said "too manyyyy"*

*And poisoned the granny Now nobody's left but
the last*

Who put the plague in the grain?

*(The king! The king!) Who called all our dying
gods rain?*

*(The king! The king!) Who's sitting up high
while we rot in the lane?*

The king, the king, the king

*Every victory has a cost and I have three
captures and thirteen names in this journal and a*

cure that works and not that many people left to give it to.

By the last verse everyone was singing it and the guards were singing it and the man who could move his arm again was crying while he sang which I had not seen before.

I don't know how far the song went after that.

It went somewhere.

A Note from the Teacher

I write this as a genuine fan of these kids. And they are, in fact, kids. From the vague, half-formed imaginings of the possibilities of an elective that leveraged chess matches to teach storytelling and structure emerged a legitimate innovation in book production. To be very honest, we stumbled here, upon this form and function.

It was never supposed to be this. Nobody asked for this. That's a tongue-in-cheek inside joke among our class when we announced that we needed a tagline. Ryann, probably half paying attention and likely thinking she had more homework, uttered, "What? Nobody asked for this." And we loved it.

The book is written by 7th and 8th graders and it shows — full of sincerity, humor (some hilariously unintentional), video game logic, manga tropes, and most unexpectedly of all, cohesion. Thanks to ad hoc AI app building that translated chess PGNs into story scaffolding, they achieved something out of pure organized chaos, love of story, and middle school joy that, perhaps, may never have been done before.

We would have been nowhere without Yoyo, whose fiery (borderline obsessive) passion drove her to sacrifice sleep constructing a sprawling story universe, building the magic system nearly

overnight, and acting as showrunner for 13 others while contributing her own story. It has been my privilege to watch them do this with almost no direction from me; my expectation was a disjointed collection of independent efforts. It is always a reminder of why I teach when students shock and amaze, but this time I'm deeply humbled by their enthusiasm, work ethic, and willingness to collaborate — an emblem of what can be achieved with full hearts and a single unified goal.

I learned a lot.

— *Joseph Song*